

The Reclaimed Land

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Drama / Family and Social Novel

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The Reclaimed Land

ERSTER BAND

Reclaiming the Land

Sankt Annen, 1901–1918

Chapter 1 - The New Dyke-Reeve

They elected Hauke Carstens dyke-reeve on a March day in 1901, and there were those in the koog who thought him too young for it, thirty-one, and did not say so aloud but only saw it, the way in the marshland one sees everything and says little. Hauke knew it. He saw it in the faces as he stepped out of the inn into the wet March air, and he took it with him, the way he took everything, without expression. The land lay flat beneath the sky, so flat that the sky was the greater thing and the land only a dark line beneath it. Whoever grew up here learned early that there was no above to hold to, only the wide expanse and the wind that came from the west and never quite stopped. Over the marsh the dwelling-mounds lay like islands, the warften, artificial hills onto which the farmsteads had been set, high enough that the water would not reach them at flood tide, and on the largest mound of the Sankt-Annen-Koog stood the Carstens farm, as it had for four generations, and Hauke was the fifth.

The day after the election he walked the dyke with old Okke Nissen, who had been dyke-warden as long as Hauke could remember. Okke was a bony man with a face like untanned leather, and he walked slowly, with the deliberateness of one who knows the dyke does not run off and neither does the water. They walked on the crown of the dyke, and to their right lay the won land, the marsh, fat and fertile, with its ditches and sluice-drains, and to their left lay the water, grey and patient, behind the foreland and the brushwood groynes that had been built out into it to wrest the silt from the sea.

"There," said Okke, and pointed with his chin at a spot at the dyke's foot where the grass grew differently, darker, more lush. "There the water stands too long. It seeps through. You must remember that, Hauke. The dyke talks, if you listen. The grass tells you where it grows tired."

Hauke looked. He saw it now that Okke showed it: the darker line, the rich green that meant nothing good, for here only what had too much water grew lush. "What does it cost to put right?"

Okke looked at him from the side, and in the leathery face something moved that was almost a smile and never became one. "That's what you ask first. What it costs." He walked on. "Your father always asked the price first too. And your grandfather. It's the question of the Carstenses."

"It's a reasonable question."

"It's a reasonable question," said Okke. "Until it isn't."

They walked the whole dyke, three hours, and Okke showed him everything, every spot where the mountain — that was what the old people called the dyke, the mountain, as if there were mountains up here — every spot where the mountain was weak, where it held, where they had patched last year. Hauke listened and remembered it all, for that was what a dyke-reeve had to be able to do: know the dyke like his own body, every spot, every weakness, every cracking. The office was not an honour, even if the people called it so. The office was responsibility for the lives of all who lived behind the dyke, and whoever forgot that learned it in the first heavy tide.

At home, on the warft, Antje was waiting. She stood in the doorway of the great farmhouse, one hand at the small of her back, for the first child was on the way, and she watched him come up the mound path, slowly, with the gait of one who has

been three hours on the dyke. She did not say she was glad. She said: "How does the dyke stand?"

"It stands," said Hauke. "At one spot the water stands too long. By the sluice. Okke wants me to put it right."

"Then put it right."

"It costs."

Antje looked at him, and her gaze was clear and without detour, as it always was, and Hauke had learned that this gaze saw more than he liked. "Everything costs," she said. "A dead man costs more." She stepped aside and let him in, into the warmth of the farmhouse, into the smell of cattle and peat and boiled cabbage, and Hauke went in, and outside, behind the dyke, the water rose to the flood, as it rose twice a day, as it had since the world began, and sank again, patient, and each time took a little silt and laid down a little silt, and no one could see by looking what it intended.

In the night Hauke lay awake and listened to the water. You could hear it, when the wind stood right, the working of the tide at the sluice, a sucking and pressing, and Hauke lay and heard it and reckoned. He reckoned what the spot by the sluice would cost, done properly, with new clay and faggots, and he reckoned what it cost to patch it, cheaply, for this year. And he thought that a heavy tide came rarely, every ten, every twenty years, and that one could put right a great deal by then, and that the money saved now would benefit the farm, the child that was coming. He thought that, and he knew at the same time that Okke was right, that it was a reasonable question, until it wasn't. But the tide was far off, and the child was near, and Hauke fell asleep before he had decided, and believed he had decided nothing.

Chapter 2 - The Neighbour

Momme Feddersen had stood for the office of dyke-reeve, and he had not got it, and that lay between the two men, whether they named it or not. They did not name it. They worked side by side on the dyke, as they had worked side by side for years, for the Feddersen warft lay nearest to the Carstens warft, and in the marshland the nearest neighbour was the thing a life hung on when the water came. Momme was four years older than Hauke and broader, a man with hands like spades and a feel for the water that Hauke secretly admired and did not let show. Momme could read the dyke like no other, almost better than Okke, for Okke read it with the experience of years and Momme with something innate, an instinct for the spot where the mountain would give way. If the election had gone by who knew the dyke best, Momme would have had the office. But the election did not go by that. It went by the farm, the name, the land, and the Carstenses had more land and an older name, and so Hauke became dyke-reeve and Momme stayed what he was: a good man on the dyke who served under a younger one.

One day in the first summer they worked together on the groynes, out in the foreland, where one wrested the silt from the water. One stuck rows of brushwood fences into the watt floor, scrub between posts, and the water left its silt in them at each flood, and over the years new land grew from the sea, centimetre by centimetre, until one could dyke it in. It was patient work, work for generations, and Hauke liked it, because it was the only thing that won from the water instead of the other way round.

They stood knee-deep in the silt, and the flood came, faster than Hauke had thought, for the water in the watt always came faster than one thought; it did not come from in front, it came from everywhere, filled the channels, the runnels, cut off one's way back before one noticed. Hauke felt the ground beneath him soften, felt the suck as he tried to lift a foot and could not, and for a moment there was the cold clarity of danger, the knowledge that the watt swallowed people, every year, who misjudged the channel.

Momme was at him in three strides. He had firm ground beneath him, somehow, with the feel he had, and he gripped Hauke by the arm and pulled him out, out of the soft ground, onto the groyne, onto firm footing. It went quickly and without words, and then they both stood on the brushwood, and the water rose around them, and Momme looked at him and grinned, the broad grin that fit so badly with his usual reticence.

"Dyke-reeve," said Momme. "Mind you don't drown before you've warmed your office chair."

"Thank you," said Hauke.

"Nothing to thank." Momme let go of his arm. "Out here it doesn't count who holds the office. Out here it counts only who holds your arm when the channel takes you. One forgets that easily, up on the dyke, with the book and the inspection. But the water reminds you." He looked out, where the flood overran the groynes. "We hang together, Hauke. All of us. That's the only thing that holds us against that out there. Not the dyke. The dyke is only earth. What holds us is that no one lets the other drown."

It was a long speech for Momme Feddersen, who otherwise said little, and Hauke remembered it, the way he remembered everything. Solidarity, a man from the city would have called it.

Momme did not call it that. He did not call it anything; he only did it, pulled a man's arm from the silt and said there was nothing to thank. And Hauke, standing wet and shivering on the groyne while the flood rose around them, thought that he now owed this man his life, and that such a debt did not grow smaller with time but larger, and he did not know that one day he would think back on this day, in the storm, in the night, when the same water that Momme defeated today would take him.

On the way home, over the dyke, they looked across to the Carstens warft and to the Feddersen warft, which was smaller, poorer, nearer the water. Antje and Momme's wife stood together at the sluice-drain doing the washing, and their voices carried across the flat land, and Hauke thought that the women had it easier with the neighbourliness than the men, because between them stood no office and no land, only the work that all shared. He was wrong, but he did not know that on this day.

Chapter 3 - Dyke Duty

The dyke inspection was in spring, and it was the thing that held the koog together and divided it at once. On a day in May the inspection walked the dyke, the dyke-reeve at the front, then the sworn dyke-men, then the farmers, each responsible for his section, for so it had been arranged from of old: each farm had its stretch of dyke to maintain, according to the size of its land, and whoever let his stretch decay was punished, and in the worst case lost his land. Spadelandsrecht it was called, the old law of the marsh, and the saying that went with it was hard and simple and hung over every koog like the weather: whoever will not dyke must yield. Hayske led his first inspection, and he led it strictly, for a new dyke-reeve who was not strict counted for nothing. He walked every section and saw every spot and wrote down what was to be put right, and the farmers followed and grumbled quietly, for every spot the dyke-reeve wrote down was work and money they had to raise. So the system was: the safety of all was paid for by each one alone, and each reckoned what the safety cost him, and none reckoned what the unsafety would cost him, for the unsafety was far off and the money was near.

At the faulty spot by the sluice the inspection halted. It was the spot Okke had shown him in March, the darker grass, the seeping water, and now, in May, one saw more: the clay had grown loose, there were mouse-runs, and at one place, when one stabbed with the spade, the water came up from below, where none should be.

"That must be done properly," said Okke, loud enough for the inspection to hear. "Not patched. Done. New clay, dug out to the

firm ground, built up anew. That's two weeks' work and costs what it costs."

Hauke stood before the spot and reckoned. He reckoned in his head, fast, as he always reckoned: two weeks' work, ten men, the clay, the faggots, and that in spring, when the fields needed hands, when every day on the dyke was a day the land lacked. It was much. It was more for this one section than was needed for the whole rest of the dyke.

"We patch it for this year," said Hauke. "And do it properly in autumn, after the harvest, when the hands are free."

Okke looked at him, long, and said nothing. But Momme Feddersen, who stood in the inspection for his section, he said something. "In autumn the tide season has begun," he said. "In autumn and winter the heavy floods come, not in summer. If you do it in autumn, you may do it too late."

"It holds till autumn," said Hauke. "Patched, it holds an ordinary tide."

"And one that isn't ordinary?"

"That doesn't come every autumn, Momme."

"No," said Momme. "It doesn't come every autumn. It comes once in twenty years. But when it comes, it comes at the spot you patched and did not do. That's how the water is. It seeks out the spot where you saved money."

It went quiet in the inspection. The farmers looked from Momme to Hauke and back, and Hauke felt that more was being negotiated than a stretch of dyke. It was about the office, about the authority of the new dyke-reeve, and if he now gave way before Momme Feddersen, who had wanted the office himself, then he had lost as dyke-reeve before he had begun.

"We patch it," said Hauke once more, firmly, and it was meant to sound firm and sounded defiant. "And do it in autumn. That is my word as dyke-reeve."

Momme looked at him, and in his face there was no triumph and no anger, only a kind of regret that was worse than both. He nodded slowly. "Your word as dyke-reeve," he said. "Good. But write in your book that I warned. That the spot won't hold what you credit it with."

"Write it in the book, Okke," said Hauke, and it was meant to sound firm and sounded petulant.

And Okke, who kept the dyke book, the old book in which one had entered for a hundred years what happened at the dyke, Okke wrote it in the book. He wrote the faulty spot by the sluice, wrote that it had been patched and not done, wrote that a warning had been given. Hauke watched him write, saw the pen go across the paper, and he said nothing, and in him was a feeling he did not want to name, something between defiance and a first, distant unease. The inspection moved on, along the dyke, and behind them stayed the spot, patched for this year, and the entry in the book, black on white, and the water that lay before it, grey and patient, and remembered where one had saved.

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Chapter 4 - The Faulty Spot

Autumn came, and with it the harvest, and the harvest bound all hands, as Hauke had foreseen and secretly hoped. It was a good year, a full one, the corn stood heavy, and one could not harvest and dig at the dyke at once, everyone saw that, that was no idleness, that was the reason of the marsh. So the spot by the sluice was not done, not in autumn, not properly, as Hauke had promised before the inspection. It stayed as it was, patched, and Hauke told himself one would do it the next spring, certainly, first of all, before anything else. But Momme Fedderson did not forget the spot. He went there, of his own accord, on a day in October, and looked at it, and that evening he came to Hauke on the warft, which he rarely did, and stood in the doorway of the farmhouse, his cap in his hand, and said: "The spot is getting worse."

"It's harvest time, Momme."

"The harvest is nearly in. In two weeks the hands are free." Momme took a step inside, and the lamplight fell on his face, which was serious, more serious than usual. "Hauke, I'm not telling you this because I wanted the office and didn't get it. That's over, I don't hold it against you. I'm telling you because I've seen the spot. The water comes through now already, at an ordinary tide. The clay won't hold any more. If a heavy tide comes, this winter, it'll break there. Not somewhere else. There."

Hauke stood at the table, and Antje sat by the hearth and listened without looking up, and sewed, and Hauke felt that she was listening, and that made it worse. "We'll do it in spring," he said. "Properly. I promise you."

"In spring the tide season is over. In spring it's easy to do it, because the danger is past. That's no art, Hauke." Momme looked at him, and in his gaze there was now something hard. "The art is to do it now, before the winter, where it's difficult and expensive and where the hands are needed elsewhere. That's the office. Not the easy spot at the easy time. The hard one at the hard time."

"I'm the dyke-reeve, Momme."

"Yes," said Momme. "You are." He put his cap back on. "Then decide as dyke-reeve. But don't decide for your farm. Decide for the koog. That's the difference, and you'll learn it, one way or another." He nodded to Antje, curtly, and went out into the autumn night, and Hauke heard his steps fade across the mound path.

For a while it was quiet in the farmhouse. Then Antje said, without looking up, without stopping the needle: "He's right."

"It costs two weeks' work, now, when —"

"He's right, Hauke. You know it. You know it better than he does, for you have the book and the inspection and the responsibility. You know the spot won't hold. And you don't do it, because it's expensive and because the tide may not come." Now she looked up, and her gaze met his, clear and without mercy. "May not. You're staking the koog on a may-not. That's what you're doing."

"A heavy tide comes once in twenty years."

"And if it comes this year?"

Hauke had no answer to that, and that was the answer. He went to the door and looked out, into the night, across the flat land toward the dyke one did not see, only sensed, and behind it the water one heard when the wind stood. He thought: If I do the spot now, I give Momme the right of it, then the passed-over man

has schooled the new dyke-reeve, before the whole koog, for the whole koog would know. And he thought: If I don't do it and it goes well, then I've saved money and kept my authority. And if it does not go well — but that he did not think to the end. He left the thought at the edge, where it did not hurt, the way one leaves an entry in the book at the edge, unread.

"In spring," he said once more, quietly, more to himself than to Antje.

Antje said nothing more. She sewed on, and the child in her, that would come soon, kicked against her hand, and she laid her hand a moment on her belly, and Hauke saw it and turned away. Outside the wind went through the night, from the west, and carried up the working of the tide, the sucking and pressing at the sluice, at the spot that had not been done, and no one slept well that night on the Carstens warft, and outside, in the dark, the water came and went and remembered, tide by tide, where the man had saved.

Chapter 5 - The Spring Tide

The winter of 1906 came early and hard, and at the beginning of December the wind turned to northwest and stayed there. That was the dangerous thing, not the storm alone, but the wind that stood, day after day, for a standing northwest pressed the water of the North Sea into the bight, pressed it against the coast, higher and higher, and when then a spring tide came as well, the high tide at new or full moon, the water piled up over all the marks one knew. Okke Nissen read the weather like a book, and on a day in December he came to the Carstens warft, without his cap, his thin hair in the wind, and his leathery face was grey. "One's coming," he said. "A heavy one. The wind's stood four days, and the day after tomorrow is spring tide. That'll give one such as we haven't had in a long time."

Hauke felt the cold come over him, and it was not the wind. "How high?"

"Higher than the marks. How high, only the water knows. But high." Okke looked at him. "The spot by the sluice, Hauke."

"I know."

"It won't hold that."

"I know, Okke." Hauke said it sharply, more sharply than he meant, and Okke only nodded and said no more, for what was there to say now. Now it was too late to do the spot; one could not in two days, in this weather, properly mend a dyke section. One could only watch it, in the night, with men and sandbags and faggots, and hope it held, or, if it gave way, prevent the worst.

Hauke called up the whole koog. That was the right and the duty of the dyke-reeve: at a threatening storm tide every man had to come to the dyke, every one, without exception, for a breach hit all. They came, in the dusk of the storm day, with spades and lanterns, in oilskins, and Hauke divided them, section by section, and it was a strange hour, in which the whole koog stood at the dyke, rich and poor, Carstens and Feddersen and all the others, united against the one thing that threatened them all.

He divided the watches, and when he came to the spot by the sluice, the faulty spot, he needed a man who understood the water, one who would recognise when it grew critical, one to whom one could entrust the most dangerous spot. And without long thought, half from reason, half from something else he did not admit to himself, he said: "Momme. You take the spot by the sluice. You know it. You know what to watch for."

Momme looked at him. It was a long look, and in it lay much: the knowledge that this was the most dangerous spot; the knowledge that Hauke had been warned and not heeded; and something like bitterness, that now of all men he should guard the spot he had warned against. "The spot I said would break," said Momme.

"It holds best if there's one there who knows it."

"Or it takes the one who's there." Momme said it without reproach, almost calmly, a statement. Then he took his spade. "Good. I'll take the spot." He went there, through the storm, to the faulty spot by the sluice, and Hauke watched him go, and in him was a pull he did not want to name.

Antje, hauling sandbags with the other women, had heard the assignment. She came to Hauke, the kerchief tight around her head, and said into his ear, against the storm: "You're sending

Momme to the spot."

"He knows it best."

"You're sending him to the spot you know can break." She looked at him, and in her eyes was something Hauke had never seen there before, a fright that went deeper than the fear of the flood. "Hauke."

"It's the best assignment," said Hauke, and it did not sound convinced, and Antje heard it. But there was no time left, for the flood rose, faster now, and the gauge at the sluice already stood over the first mark, and rose further, over the second, and the wind howled across the dyke and tore the words from the men's mouths, and the water came, grey and black and higher than anything the living knew, and pressed against the dyke, against the spot that had not been done, and Momme Feddersen stood before it, with his lantern, alone in the storm, and guarded it.

Chapter 6 - The Breach

It happened in the third hour after midnight, when the tide reached its peak, and it happened as Momme had foretold: at the spot by the sluice, not somewhere else. Hauke was at his own section, a stretch further on, and he heard it sooner than he saw it. It was a sound he never forgot, though it nearly drowned in the storm: a sagging, a dull giving-way of the earth, and then the water, which no longer pressed but streamed, with a roar that was different from the roar of the storm, deeper, greedier. The dyke had given way. The mountain had broken.

Hauke knew at once where. He knew it without looking, with the certainty of one who knew the spot, who had been warned, who had seen the entry in the book. The spot by the sluice. Momme's spot. He let the spade fall and ran, against the storm, along the dyke crown, and his heart beat in his throat, and he prayed, without knowing he prayed, that it was not so bad, that Momme had drawn back in time, that no one —

He came to the spot. In the light of the few lanterns still burning he saw the breach: the dyke was torn away over twenty metres, and through the gap the water shot into the koog, a black, roaring stream that swept everything with it. And in the water, in the breach, in the whirling, roaring dark, he saw Momme for a moment. He saw him struggle, saw the arms, saw the face that looked up to him, and then the water tore him away, into the koog, into the darkness, and Hauke saw him no more.

"Momme!" Hauke cried it into the storm, and the storm took it from his mouth. He wanted to go down, into the breach, into the

water, but hands held him fast, Okke's hands, other hands, for whoever climbed into that breach was lost, the water was too strong, swept everything with it, and a dead dyke-reeve saved no one.

"You can't!" Okke cried into his ear. "You can't go after him! The water takes you too!"

They held him, and Hauke stood on the breaking dyke and watched the water stream into his koog, into the land he was to have secured, through the spot he had not had done. Below, in the koog, the lights went out, one farm after another, as the water reached them; one heard the cattle bellow, heard cries, far off, in the storm. The warften became islands, one after another, and the water rose in the land, where no water should be, and Hauke stood and watched it and could do nothing, nothing more, for what should have been done one would have had to do in autumn, or in spring, or on the day the inspection halted before the spot and Okke said it must be done, not patched.

The night was long. They saved what they could, pulled people from roofs and from the rising water, drove cattle onto the warften, hauled bags into the breach that the water tore out again. The Carstens warft held; it lay high and far from the breach, and Antje and the maids brought the cattle into the farmhouse and stoked fires and cooked for those who arrived soaked and half-frozen. But the lower warften, nearer the breach, filled up, and the Feddersen warft, the smallest, the poorest, lay in the midst of the new water, and by morning of it one saw only the roof.

When the first grey light crept over the flooded land, Hauke stood at the edge of the breach, through which the water now streamed more slowly, because the level inside the koog and

outside had equalised. They had not found Momme. They would find him later, in the silt, a stretch inland, where the water had carried him. Hauke stood and looked over the land that had become a sea, grey water to the horizon, out of which the warften rose like the backs of drowning animals, and he knew, with a clarity that made him colder than the storm, why the spot had broken, and who had guarded it, and that the two were connected, and that he would never be able to make it not have happened, all his life.

Okke stepped beside him. The old man said nothing for a long time. Then he said, quietly, so only Hauke heard: "The book, Hauke. It's in there. That the spot wasn't done. That a warning was given."

Hauke did not answer. He looked over the water, and in him formed, before he even thought it, the first line of what he would do, what he would not do, what he would say and not say. And Okke, who had turned his leathery face into the grey, waited to see if the dyke-reeve would say something, and the dyke-reeve said nothing, and in that silence, on the morning after the flood, over the drowned land, the other thing began, the thing that would last longer than any flood.

Chapter 7 - An Act of God

The authority came from the county town, three days after the flood, when the water was slowly beginning to run off again, through the breach and through the sluices, and the land emerged from the sea once more, muddy, devastated, with dead animals and broken fences and a thick layer of silt over everything. A hydraulic inspector came and an official from the district administrator, and they recorded the breach, as one recorded such breaches: soberly, measuring, with the wish to find a cause that struck no one. They found what they sought. A spring tide at standing northwest, a level that exceeded all known marks, a force of nature against which no dyke in the world was safe. An act of God. That was the formula, and it fit, for it was half true: the tide had really been exceptional, the level really beyond all marks. That the dyke broke at precisely the weakest spot, at the spot one knew and had not done — that could be explained otherwise too, and the inspector, who did not know the koog, had no reason to ask otherwise.

Hauke gave his statement. He gave it as dyke-reeve, terse, in firm sentences, and he told the truth, as far as it served him. He said the tide had exceeded all marks. He said the dyke had been in proper condition after the last inspection. He said one had done what was possible. What he did not say — and only Antje, who was permitted to be present because she was the dyke-reeve's wife, heard the silence around this one spot — was that he had known of the weakness by the sluice. That Okke had advised a thorough repair. That Momme had warned, twice, three times.

That there was an entry in the dyke book. He said nothing of it, and the concealing was no lie in the strict sense, for no one asked him; it was only the leaving-out of what would have struck him, and that was almost worse, because it was so easy.

Then it was Okke's turn. Okke Nissen, the dyke-warden, who kept the dyke book in which the entry stood. The inspector asked him about the condition of the dyke, and Okke, who could not lie and would not lie, said the dyke was old and at many a spot tired, as every dyke was. The inspector asked whether there had been known weak spots. And Okke —

Okke was silent a moment too long. Hauke saw it, saw the old man wrestle, saw how the knowledge lay on his tongue, the entry, the warning, the faulty spot. One word, and it would have been out, and Hauke would have been a man of acts of God no longer, but a dyke-reeve who out of thrift had not done a spot at which a man drowned. One word.

Okke said: "Weak spots, every dyke has. You inspect them, you patch them. More a man cannot do against the water." He did not look at Hauke as he said it. He looked at his hands, the old, spotted hands that had kept the book, and he did not lie, for what he said was true — and he did not say the whole truth, for he named neither the entry nor the warning nor the one spot. It was loyalty, perhaps. It was fear, perhaps, of what it meant to accuse the dyke-reeve, to split the koog in a time when the koog had to hold together to survive. It was the reason of the marsh, which made silence cheaper than speech. Whatever it was, Okke now carried it too, and with him the dyke book, in which the truth stood black on white and which no one opened.

Momme's death was recorded as an accident in the dyke service. A brave man, it said, who did his duty at an endangered

spot and was taken by the water. It was true, every word, and it left out the one thing: that the spot was endangered because one had not done it, and that the one who knew this was the man who had stationed him there. Momme's widow received a small compensation, as was due to the bereaved, and the authority departed, and the koog stayed with its devastation and its dead man and its formula: an act of God.

In the evening, when it was all over, Hauke and Antje sat in the parlour, and neither said anything. Then Antje looked at him, long, and in her gaze there was no accusation, but something heavier: the knowledge that they now belonged together, more firmly than by the marriage certificate, welded together by what he had done and concealed and she had not prevented. She could have stood up, could have gone to the authority, could have named the entry in the book. She did not. She stood up, stoked the fire, hung the pot over it, and said: "Eat. It was a long day." And that was her part of the silence, her own, and they laid it together over what had happened, the way the water laid the silt over the devastated land, thick and smooth and covering everything.

Chapter 8 - Who Dykes, Gains

The koog had to be dyked in again, and Hauke did it, with an energy that was almost obsession. He was everywhere, from the first day: organised the closing of the breach, procured clay and faggots, divided the men, worked himself, to exhaustion. The people saw it and said the young dyke-reeve took the flood to heart, he worked as if he wanted to make the disaster un-happen with his own hands, and that did him credit. They did not know that they were right, only differently than they meant: Hauke worked against something that could not be worked away, and the more he worked, the less it helped, for the work was no atonement, it was only a humbling. They closed the breach, and they made the dyke higher and stronger than it had been, higher than the new mark the flood of 1906 had set. That was the lesson the koog drew from every flood: one built the dyke to the last flood, always one flood too late, for the next would be higher again, that was the old game between the human and the water, a game the human never won and never quite lost.

And then came the new survey. For a part of the land could not be reclaimed, at least not at once. The deepest stretch of the koog, where the breach had been and the water had stood longest, stayed wet, salted, useless, and it was decided to lead the new dyke a stretch inland and leave this deepest stretch outside for now, to the water, as foreland. It was a sensible decision, a technical one, and it had a consequence no one said aloud: in this abandoned stretch lay the Feddersen warft. Momme's farm. His land.

So the Feddersen widow lost what had remained to her. The farm was flooded anyway, the warft half washed away, but the land that belonged to it, which now lay outside the new dyke, that was worth nothing any more, was foreland, given over to the water. And through the same survey the Carstens farm gained: land that had once bordered the Feddersens fell now, through the new dyke line, to the Carstens side, to Hauke's farm. It was no intention, Hauke told himself, it was the geography, the technology, the most sensible line for the new dyke. And yet the result was that Hauke gained where Momme died, that his farm grew larger out of the flood that his spot had broken.

Hauke tried to help the widow. He sent her corn, secretly, through a maid, and money, anonymously, he thought. The widow sent the corn back. She came herself, on a winter day, across the muddy mound path, a woman who had aged twenty years in one night, and she set the sack of corn before Antje's door and said, when Antje opened: "We take nothing from the house of Carstens." She said it calmly, almost toneless. "My husband stood at your spot. At the spot he warned of. You know that, Antje Carstens. You know it as well as I do." And she went, without another word, and left the sack standing, and Antje picked it up and closed the door and said nothing, and from that day the women did not greet each other, who had once washed together at the sluice.

The widow knew, then. Perhaps Momme had told her, before the flood, of the warning and the not-being-heard; perhaps she knew it only with the certainty of women who read their men's silences like the weather. She had no proof, as little as Antje had proof, as little as little Thies Feddersen, Momme's son, who was now fatherless and impoverished. But she knew, and her knowing

was an accusation that weighed the more because it never came to court, but lived only in a returned sack of corn, in an unreturned greeting, in the knowledge of two families that would inherit like the land itself.

At night Antje laid her hand on Hauke's back, in the dark, and Hauke lay awake and listened to the water, which now stood behind a higher dyke, further off, but not gone, never quite gone. He had gained. His farm was larger, his dyke stronger, his office secured, for a dyke-reeve who rebuilt so vigorously after the flood counted for something. He had gained everything there was to gain, and he knew he had lost it, in the same moment he gained it, and that no higher dyke and no larger land ever again balanced this one reckoning.

Chapter 9 - The Boy at His Hand

Bo was born two years after the flood, in 1908, in a mild spring, and at first Hauke saw in the child only what every father sees in his firstborn: the continuation, the heir, the one for whom one worked. Only later, as the boy grew, did he see other things, and Bo grew up on the warft, in the shadow of the dyke, and like all marsh children he learned early to read the water. Hauke took him along on the dyke, as Okke had once taken him, and showed him what a Carstens had to know: where the dyke was strong and where tired, how to read the grass, how to read the gauge at the sluice. The boy learned fast, faster than others, and he learned with a seriousness, a doggedness, that was not childlike. Bo wanted to do everything right, wanted to be the best, and Hauke recognised the ambition, because it was his own, the same hunger for standing, the same need to be something in this flat, hard land.

And Hauke feared him. He feared the ambition in his own son, because he knew where it could lead: to the faulty spot one does not do because it is expensive; to the sensible thrift that is no longer thrift but a gamble with the lives of others. He saw it sprouting in the boy and could say nothing against it, for the only thing he would have had to say — beware where your ambition drives you, I know it, I followed it, and a man died of it — that he could not say, never.

Thies Feddersen, Momme's son, was a few years older than Bo. After the flood the Feddersens were impoverished; the land before the dyke was worthless, the warft destroyed, the widow scraped by on the little that remained. And when Thies was old

enough, he had to go to work, and there was hardly work for an impoverished boy except at the larger farms, and the largest farm nearby was the Carstenses'. So it came about that Thies Feddersen started as a herd-boy at Hauke's, at the man at whose faulty spot his father had drowned.

It was a humiliation no one spoke of and all saw. The son of the drowned Momme herded the cattle of the dyke-reeve who had not had the spot done. Hauke gave him good wages, more than usual, and it helped nothing, made it worse if anything, for everyone in the koog understood what these good wages were: an atonement that did not speak its name, a guilt-money that bore no name. Thies took the wages, because his mother needed them, and he took them with a face that betrayed nothing, a closed, hard boy's face, and Hauke could not look him in the eye.

But the two boys, Bo and Thies, cared nothing for what lay between the fathers. They scuffled and played, as boys do, herded the cattle together, built dams in the ditches, raced each other across the dyke. For them the old story was nothing, a matter of the grown-ups, a silence whose ground they did not know. Sometimes Hauke saw them sitting together on the dyke, his own son and the dead man's son, two small figures against the wide sky, and something contracted in him, and he turned away.

"Leave them," said Antje, when he once spoke of not knowing whether it was right that Bo played with the Feddersen boy. "You won't get the old story out of the children by separating them. Perhaps it's good that they're together. Perhaps it heals, a generation on, what we broke, if only we let it."

"And if it doesn't heal?" said Hauke. "If it only sleeps and wakes later?"

Antje had no answer to that, and neither did Hauke. They let the boys play, and they grew up, the one to be heir of a farm that stood on a guilt, the other to be a hand on that very farm, and neither of them knew it, and over them stood the high sky of the marsh, beneath which everything was visible and nothing was said.

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Chapter 10 - War and Dyke

When the war came, in the summer of 1914, it drew the young men out of the koog, as it drew them everywhere, and the flat land grew emptier still than it already was. The farms stayed with the old, the women, the half-grown, and the dyke, which did not ask whether it was war or peace, the dyke had to be held all the same, with half a crew. Hauke was too old for the front, forty-six, and he was dyke-reeve, and a dyke-reeve was needed where he was. So he stayed and held the dyke, and he held it with the hands that were left: with old men who remembered floods the young had only heard of, with women who dug as well as men, with boys like Bo and Thies who had to lend a hand earlier than their age foresaw. Every repair now became a question of sacrifice: whoever dug at the dyke was missing in the field, and there were too few hands for both.

Thies Feddersen went to the war. He had grown old enough, and he went half voluntarily, half out of defiance, as his father had once half out of defiance warned. Perhaps it was the prospect of escaping the koog, the place where he was the drowned man's son, the hand on the farm that had his father on its conscience. Perhaps it was only what drove all young men that summer, the enthusiasm one no longer understood afterward. Hauke watched him go, with the others, to the station in the county town, and he thought of Momme, who now saw even his only son go off to a war, the war of the gentlemen, for whom a Feddersen counted as little as a Carstens, and yet the Carstens son Bo, too young for the front, counted more in this world than the Feddersen son, who

was old enough to die.

Hunger came with the war, slowly, the way the water came at flood, first imperceptibly, then everywhere. The marsh nourished, it gave corn and cattle, but the state took, requisitioned, and what remained was not enough. Antje ran the economy of scarcity, as she ran everything, with iron precision, and Hauke saw her grow thinner and the children too, and he, as dyke-reeve, had a little more influence, a little more possibility, and he used it, as he always used it: not only for himself.

For Hauke gave. He had never quite stopped giving since the flood, secretly, to the widows, to the poor, to the families of those the war took. And more than to all, he gave, through go-betweens, to the Feddersen widow, whose son now stood in the field, who was alone on her half-warft before the dyke. It did not help him, he knew that; it did not make the breach un-happen, did not give Momme back his life. It was an atonement that calmed only him, not the one to whom the wrong had been done. But he did it all the same, because he could not leave it, because a man who carries such a guilt must do something, even if it is the wrong thing, the insufficient thing.

In that war year a smaller storm tide came, in autumn, nothing against 1906, but enough to call the koog to dyke watch. And the new dyke held. The spot by the sluice, which was now done properly — that Hauke had done first of all after the flood, higher and stronger than everything — that held without difficulty. Hauke stood that night at this very spot, at the spot where Momme had drowned, and the new, strong dyke held the water, and he felt no relief, only a cold bitterness: that he now did, thoroughly and without hesitation, what he had then saved on, and that this Now helped a dead man not at all. He inspected the

dyke from then on with the fear of the one who knows, over-thoroughly, left no spot weak any more, spent no money out of thrift, and the koog praised its conscientious dyke-reeve, and no one knew that this conscientiousness had a dead man at its root.

Chapter 11 - Antje's Question

The hunger winter of 1917 struck the marsh like everyone, and in that winter Hauke again gave more than he could, of the little the farm had. He carried it away, in the dark, as he had for years, to the Feddersen widow, to other needy ones, and he believed no one noticed, least of all Antje. But Antje noticed everything. She ran the economy, she counted the corn, she knew what was missing. One evening, when he again came home with a half-empty sack, she confronted him. She did not do it loudly. She stood at the hearth, stirring the thin gruel, and said, without turning round: "Who are you atoning for, Hauke?"

It was the same word that another woman in another land in another winter would say to another man, and Hauke did not know it and yet felt it: it was the word that named everything. Atoning. He was silent.

"You carry the corn to the Feddersen widow," said Antje. "For the third time this month. While your own children grow thinner at the table. Why, Hauke?"

"She's alone. Her husband is dead. Her son in the war."

"Her husband is dead." Antje turned round, the spoon in her hand, and her gaunt face was hard in the glow of the hearth-fire. "Yes. Her husband is dead. He stood at the spot by the sluice, Hauke. At the spot you knew would not hold. Of which Momme warned you. Which you should have had done in autumn and did not." She said it calmly, almost without accusation, as if she were reading something long written. "That's what you atone for. Not from pity. From guilt."

It was the first time in eleven years that she spoke it, the one thing that stood between them since the flood night. She had always known it — since the inspection, since Momme's visit in autumn, since the assigning of the watches, since the questioning by the authority at which Hauke kept silent. She had known it and never said it, and now she said it, half, in their own parlour, in the hunger winter, and it lay between them like a stone one finally names.

Hauke could have said everything now. He could have said: Yes. I knew. I saved money, and a man died for it, and I carry it every day. He could have said it to Antje, the only one before whom he need not dissemble, because she knew it anyway. But he did not say it. He said: "It's war, Antje. The widow has no one. Should I let her starve?"

It was no answer, and Antje knew it was none. "Give her what you must," she said and turned back to the hearth. "But don't tell me it's pity. I know you, Hauke. You atone. And atoning makes nothing good. It only makes it bearable for you." She stirred the gruel. "The dead man stays dead, whether you bring the widow corn or not. The only thing you'd owe her is the truth. And that you don't give her. Rather the corn than the truth. That's how you are."

It was the hardest and truest thing she had ever said to him, and Hauke carried it off, as he carried everything off. He went out into the night, before the door of the farmhouse, and stood in the wind that came from the west, and heard the water far behind the dyke. And he understood that Antje now knew fully what he knew, and that she carried it all the same, in silence, that she had settled into the carrying, the way the land settles into being embanked, behind a wall that holds and yet is never quite safe.

She had become the silent woman who knows everything. And Hauke knew that he had made her so, and that too he carried, on top of everything else.

Chapter 12 - The Dyke Book

The war ended in 1918, and it ended for the marsh as everywhere: in exhaustion, in scarcity, in a stillness that was no relief. Thies Feddersen came back, other than he had gone, more silent, harder, with eyes that had seen too much. He took up his work at the farm again, and Hauke again gave him the good wages, and between the two men lay the same silence as before the war, only grown deeper. In that winter, when everything returned to the old, poorer order, Okke Nissen came to the Carstens warft. The dyke-warden had grown old, over seventy, his hands trembled, and he could no longer serve the office. He came to hand over the dyke book, the old book in which one had entered for a hundred years what happened at the dyke, and which now passed into the dyke-reeve's keeping, as was the custom when a dyke-warden laid down his office.

Okke laid the book on the table, the heavy, leather-bound book, and his trembling hands rested on it a moment. "It's all in there," he said. "A hundred years of dyke. Every flood, every repair, every inspection." He looked at Hauke, and in the leathery, aged face was something Hauke could not interpret and yet understood. "That of nineteen-hundred-six too. The faulty spot. That it was patched and not done. That a warning was given." A pause. "It's in there, Hauke. I entered it, back then, as was my duty. I couldn't leave it out. But I also told no one. That was my sin, if you will. That I entered it and then kept silent."

Hauke looked at the book. "Why did you say nothing? To the authority, back then. You could have —"

"I know what I could have done." Okke took his hands off the book. "I could have brought you down. Split the koog, in the year we had to hold together to survive. I didn't do it. Out of loyalty, I told myself. Out of cowardice, I tell myself now, old as I am and not long for it. It was both." He looked at Hauke. "But the book I wrote as it was. That was the one thing I did right. What you do with it is your affair. You can tear out the page. No one would notice. Or you let it stand."

And Okke went, slowly, with the trembling hands, out into the winter, and Hauke stayed alone with the book.

That night he opened it, by the light of the lamp, and leafed until he found the page. There it stood, in Okke's old, orderly hand: the date, the faulty spot by the sluice, the note that it had been patched and not thoroughly done, that the dyke-reeve had been warned. Black on white, the truth that no one knew, that no one had read except Okke and now Hauke.

He held the book nearer the lamp. He could have torn out the page. It would have been sensible; it would have erased the last trace, the last testimony. He took the page between his fingers. And then he left it. He left it standing, the page, the entry, the truth, and he did not quite know why, only that it was impossible for him to destroy it, as it had been impossible for him to speak the truth. Perhaps it was cowardice, like Okke's. Perhaps it was something else, something that was almost hope: that one distant day there would be someone who opened the book, who read, who asked, and that then there should be something that answered, when all the mouths that now kept silent had long fallen quiet. He could not say it. But he could let the entry stand, for the one who would come.

He closed the book and laid it in the chest, with the other farm papers, and outside it was still, quite still, because frost had covered the land and even the water at the sluice had come to rest. Bo, now ten, slept in the next room, and in the morning he would go again to the field and to the dyke, the boy who would one day inherit the book, with the chest, with the entry, without knowing what he inherited. And Hauke sat long by the light of the lamp and looked at the chest in which the truth now lay, enclosed, kept, passed on, and he thought that one does not get rid of a guilt by walling it up, as little as one gets rid of the sea by building a dyke. Both remain. Both press. And one day both find a spot where one has saved.

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Chapter 13 - Inflation and Land

The money died in the early twenties, and it died in the marsh too, although the marsh was far from the cities where one carried the notes in a washing basket. Hauke had saved, in the years as dyke-reeve, in the good harvest years; he had set aside what he could, a cushion for the farm, for Bo's future. And it evaporated, almost overnight, became worthless paper, as everywhere. But unlike a man in the city who had nothing but his money, Hauke had the land. And the land remained. It could not be devalued, not printed worthless overnight; it lay where it lay, fat and fertile, the won land of the marsh, and with it the stretch that had fallen to him out of the flood, through the new dyke line, the land that had once bordered the Feddersens. While the money of the rise evaporated, the ground of the rise remained: the land he had gained where Momme lost.

Antje saw him sitting at the table with the worthless notes, and she said the sentence Hauke did not forget, soberly, almost gently: "Land doesn't lie, but it doesn't forget either." She meant the money that vanished and the land that remained. And she meant the other, the land on which their prosperity stood, the stretch that had come out of the flood. She meant both, and both knew it.

In that winter the Feddersen widow died. She died poor, on the half-warft before the dyke, in the land that was worth nothing any more, of the lung, of poverty, of the years of privation. She was not an old woman, but she looked like one. Thies, returned from the war, now stood alone, the last Feddersen, without father, without mother, without land, a labourer on others' farms, and his

face had grown hard and closed like the water in frost.

Hauke went to the burial. He could have stayed away; no one expected the dyke-reeve at the grave of the poor widow whose husband had drowned at his spot. But he went, because he could not do otherwise, because something in him had to stand at this grave. He stood at the back, at the edge of the small mourning party, and at the front stood Thies, alone, upright, in his threadbare clothes, and did not look across, until the grave was nearly closed. Then Thies raised his head and looked across the heads to where Hauke stood, and their eyes met.

Thies said no word. He said the loudest word one can say by saying no word. In his gaze lay everything: the knowledge he had from his father, of the faulty spot, the warning, the not-being-heard; the accusation that never came to court, because there was no proof except an entry in a book that lay in a chest; and a bitter, hard satisfaction that Hauke had come, that Hauke needed to come, that the dyke-reeve stood at the grave of the widow whose husband had guarded his spot. Then Thies turned away.

Hauke went home through the cold marsh, and the worthless notes rustled in his pocket, and beneath his feet lay the land that remained, the won land, his land, and he thought of Antje's word: land doesn't lie, but it doesn't forget either. The money was gone, the wage of the rise, evaporated. But the land had remained, the ground of the rise, and with it the guilt that lay in the soil, firmer than any money, un-devaluable, inheritable. And before the dyke, in the abandoned stretch, lay the sunken Feddersen warft beneath the water that came and went twice a day and let nothing be forgotten.

Chapter 14 - The Old Dyke-Reeve

Hauke grew old, as Okke had grown old, and the time came when he had to give up the office. He had held it nearly thirty years, longer than most, and he had held it well, everyone said so: a conscientious dyke-reeve who left no spot weak, who would rather over-repair than under, who never saved at the dyke. They did not know where this conscientiousness came from, and Hauke did not say. **Bo stood for** the office. He was a man now, in his mid-twenties, soon to marry, and he wanted to be what his father had been, and more: he wanted to be greater. The ambition Hauke had seen sprouting in the child had now fully blossomed, and it was uncanny to Hauke, because he knew it so exactly.

There was a last dyke inspection that Hauke and Bo walked together, the old dyke-reeve and the coming one, section by section, and Hauke showed his son everything, every spot, every weakness, every history of the dyke. And when they came to the spot by the sluice, the spot that was now for thirty years the strongest of the whole dyke, because Hauke had made it higher and firmer after the flood than everything else — there Hauke halted, and something in him wanted to speak.

"This spot," he said. "Bo. This spot you must always keep an eye on."

"It's the strongest on the whole dyke," said Bo. "One can see that."

"Yes. Now it is." Hauke looked at the spot, at the firm, high mountain beneath which the water lay, at which a man had once drowned. "It wasn't always the strongest. There was a time when

it was the weakest. There —" He faltered. The sentence lay on his tongue, the whole sentence, the truth: There the dyke broke, because I had not had the spot done, and Momme Feddersen drowned, and on that our farm stands. It lay on his tongue, at the place itself, before the son who would inherit the office and with the office the responsibility for the spot.

"There what?" asked Bo.

Hauke looked at the son, the ambitious, capable son who knew nothing, and he could not get it out. "There it was weak," he said. "Long ago. Hold the dyke, Bo. Nothing more. Hold it well. Never save at the dyke. That's all I can give you."

It was all, and it was too little, and neither knew it, the one because he did not know what was missing, the other because he could not say it. They walked the inspection to its end, and Bo was elected dyke-reeve the same year, young for the office, as Hauke had been young, and Hauke watched him take the office with a mixture of pride and fear that he could explain to no one.

Hauke died a few years later, in bed, in winter, an old man who could no longer walk the dyke. Bo sat with him in the last days, and once, in a clear moment, Hauke reached for the son's hand and said: "Bo. There is something you must know. About the flood, back then. About Momme Feddersen. About the spot —"

And then his strength left him, or his courage, or both, and the clear moment passed, and Hauke sank back and said only: "Hold the dyke. And the book — the book in the chest —" No more came. The sentence he had not said for thirty years stayed unfinished even now, at the edge of death, as it had stayed unfinished at the spot by the sluice. Hauke Carstens died with his guilt, almost whole, and took the essential with him, and left

behind only the breach, unnamed, inherited, and the dyke book in the chest, with the entry no one read.

Bo did not understand the last words. The book in the chest — he found it, leafed through it, saw a hundred years of dyke history, floods, repairs, inspections, and he found the entry of 1906 too, read it, and did not understand it, because he did not know what it pointed to; for Bo it was an old entry about an old spot that had long been the strongest. He shut the book and laid it back in the chest, and he inherited his father's silence, completely, without knowing the ground of it, and laid it, without wanting to, over his own children, who would come.

Chapter 15 - The Hereditary Farm

Bo led the farm into a time that was changing, faster than the marsh was used to. In the early thirties came first the crisis, the collapse of prices, the hardship even on the land, and then came the new time, with flags and promises and a law that seemed made precisely for the farmers of the marsh: the Reich Hereditary Farm Law. The hereditary farm. It meant the farm was indivisible, unsellable, unmortgageable, that it passed undivided to a single heir, that no bank could take it, no creditor. For a man like Bo, who set the farm above all else, who wanted to increase and hold it at any price, it was a promise he could scarcely resist: protection, security, honour, the farmer as bearer of the people, the soil as sacred. It fit everything Bo was and wanted to be, and he threw in his lot with those who promised it, without asking long what else he was making common cause with.

He had married Grete, a farmer's daughter from the neighbouring koog, clear and incorruptible like Antje once, and Grete saw the new time with other eyes than Bo. She mistrusted the flags, the promises, the noise. But she held it back, for the children's sake, and because a woman in the marsh had little say against a man who had the office and the farm and now the party behind him.

Thies Feddersen was still there, the last Feddersen, landless, a labourer, now at Bo's, as he had been at Hauke's. The old humiliation went on under a new sign: where the hereditary farm law raised and protected the farmer, it left the landless precisely what he was, without prospect, without land, for a hereditary

farm could only be held by one who already had land. Thies saw Bo rise in the new time, as he had seen Hauke rise after the flood, and his face betrayed nothing, and he worked and was silent.

Bo took over from his dead father the dyke book too, which lay in the chest. He took it out, once, leafed through it, saw the entry of 1906, which he had already seen once and not understood. This time he read it more closely: the faulty spot by the sluice, patched and not done, the dyke-reeve warned. And for a moment an inkling brushed him, a chill, a connection that did not quite fit — his father, the office, the flood in which Momme Feddersen drowned, Thies's father, who now worked for him. But Bo was not a man who pursued inklings that were uncomfortable. He shut the book, laid it back, and told himself it was an old entry about an old spot that had long been the strongest on the dyke. The father had made it so strong precisely for that reason. What should be amiss in it.

So Bo overlooked the truth that was put into his hand, because he could not interpret it and would not, and laid the book back in the chest, and with it the guilt he now carried without knowing it. And over the marsh flew the new flags, and the hereditary farm law made the Carstens farm untouchable, grown out of a flood, founded on a concealed breach, and no one asked where the prosperity came from, least of all Bo, who now increased it under the protection of the new time.

Chapter 16 - Blood and Soil

The slogans of the new time seemed made for the marsh. Blood and soil, it was called, the farmer as the root of the people, the soil as sacred, the land as the inheritance of the forebears. For a farmer whose family had wrested the same soil from the sea for five generations, that did not sound like a lie but like a confirmation of what he believed anyway: that the land was everything, that the farm counted, that the farmer was something special. Bo let himself be carried by these words, because they flattered him, because they gave him what his ambition hungered for. He became local farm leader. It was no great office, but it was power, small power over the neighbours, over the delivery quota, over the distribution, and Bo misunderstood it, as his father had once half misunderstood the dyke-reeve's office: as a rise, a duty, what was due to one who was capable. He did not see, or did not want to see, what he carried along by holding the office, what system he served by keeping lists and collecting quotas and putting himself on the side of the loud.

The first severities came, quietly at first. A neighbour who had talked too openly was fetched and came back changed. A pedlar in the county town, a Jew, was one day no longer there. One learned to lower the gaze, to see nothing, to say nothing — the old art of the marsh that Bo had inherited from his father without knowing he had inherited it, this art of looking away, of protecting one's own, of holding oneself out, while others fell. Bo looked away, as Hauke had looked away, and called it reason, called it duty for the farm, for the family.

Grete brought a child into the world that year, a son, and for one summer happiness seemed possible: the farm, the children, the fertile marsh, the garden behind the warft where Grete grew beans and cabbage. It was a real happiness, not a pretended one, a summer of sun and growth. But over the happiness lay what lay over everything in that time: the flags, the slogans, the war that was not yet there and already stood on the horizon, the way a storm tide can be read in the weather days before.

And beneath the happiness lay the soil that bore the guilt. Bo did not know it. He stood on the dyke, on an evening in that last summer of peace, and looked over his land, the won land, the fat, fertile land of the marsh, and before the dyke lay the abandoned foreland, under water, with the sunken Feddersen warft that no one saw any more, that only the old people knew. Bo saw the calm water over the foreland and thought nothing of it, thought of the harvest, of the farm, of the son who slept. He did not know that he stood on a guilt half a century old, and that he would carry it on into a time darker than anything the marsh had known, and that the water, which lay so calm over the old foreland, waited patiently, as it always waited, for a time not yet born.

Behind him, in the chest, lay the dyke book with the entry he had overlooked. Before him lay the water over the taken land. And in him, unknown, lay the breach his father had made, and now rode with him, with Bo Carstens, local farm leader and dyke-reeve, into the war and into his own guilt, which was yet to come and would so resemble the first that it was as if the water had written it a second time.

ZWEITER BAND

Storm Tide

Sankt Annen, 1934–1953

Chapter 1 - The Heir

Bo Carstens led the farm and the dyke-reeve's office with a competence no one denied him, and with a hardness some indulged him and none named aloud. He was in his mid-twenties when he took over both, and he bore it as if born to it, which in a sense he was: the fifth Carstens on the warft, heir to a farm that under the hereditary farm law was now indivisible and untouchable, grown over five generations, wrested from the sea piece by piece. He knew the dyke like his own body, every metre, every spot — except for the one secret that lay in the chest and that he had overlooked. He walked the inspections strictly, let no weakness through, did not save at the dyke; that his father had impressed on him, with his last clear words: never save at the dyke. Bo kept to it, without knowing why it had been so important to the father, and it made him a good dyke-reeve, whose conscientiousness, like the father's, had a root he did not know.

Grete ran the farm economy, and she ran it well, clear and incorruptible. She had married Bo out of reason and with affection, and she had quickly recognised what he was: a capable, ambitious man who set the farm above all and lost himself in it. She had also recognised what she could not change in him, and she had learned to live with it, as women in the marsh learned to live with what they could not change.

In the stable, in the garden, at the sluice-drain, life went its course, the old course of the marsh, which had changed little in five generations: the cattle, the corn, the tide, the dyke inspection in spring, the tide season in autumn and winter. But over this old

course now lay the new time, the flags, the slogans, the quota, the lists, and Bo was part of it, local farm leader, one who joined in, who carried out, who told himself it was only duty for farm and family.

Thies Feddersen was still on the farm, the last Feddersen, now a man in his forties, landless, a labourer, silent. He worked for Bo, as he had worked for Hauke, and between him and Bo lay the same old silence that had lain between him and Hauke, only the ground was even more unknown to Bo than to himself. Bo saw in Thies only the capable, closed worker who handled the dyke well, better almost than many a farmer; he did not see, or did not want to see, what this man carried in himself, the knowledge of the father who drowned at the spot, the bitterness of forty years.

On the horizon stood the new time, and Bo told himself the joining-in was only duty. He stood on the dyke, that spring of 1934, and looked over his land, and he was content, as far as a man like Bo could be content, who always wanted more. He did not know that he stood on a guilt, and he did not know that the time he was growing into would set him before the same choice his father had stood before: to save his own at the cost of another, and to call the wrong thing the necessary one.

Chapter 2 - Local Farm Leader

The office of local farm leader was small, measured against what it triggered in Bo. He administered the koog's delivery quota, kept lists of who had to deliver how much, corn, cattle, milk, and he decided, within the limits set him, who was favoured and who was pressed. It was power over the neighbours, and Bo, who had wanted all his life to be something, relished it without admitting it to himself. He called it order. When a smallholder did not meet the quota, Bo pressed him, hard, in the name of the regulation, and told himself he was only doing his duty; the regulation was not his, he only carried it out. It was the same self-deception with which his father had not done the faulty spot — I do only the sensible, the necessary thing — and Bo repeated it, without knowing he repeated it, for he did not know the father's story.

The hardness struck the weakest first, as it always strikes the weakest first. An old cottager who could not raise the quota because he was too ill to work; a widow whose farm was too small. Bo carried out what was prescribed, and rarely softened it, for mercy was not foreseen and made one suspect. Grete saw it and said once, cautiously: "Old Petersen can't deliver, Bo. He's ill. You know it." And Bo said: "The quota is the quota. If I turn a blind eye for one, they all come." It sounded sensible, and it was hard, and Grete was silent, for now.

Thies Feddersen came under pressure. As a labourer, landless, he was suspect anyway in a time that declared the soil sacred and mistrusted the soil-less. There were lists with names like Thies's on them, people without a farm, without firm ties, and Bo could

have protected Thies, with a word, with the surety of the employer. He did the most necessary, no more: certified that Thies was a good worker, indispensable at the dyke. It was enough to keep Thies, and it was as little as it had to be, coldly reckoned, without warmth.

Grete saw the transformation of her husband, slowly, over the months. Bo was not cruel, not by nature; he was ambitious, and the ambition made him compliant, made him one who carried out without asking, who looked away where looking hurt. It was the transformation of many in that time, no special one, and precisely that made it bad: that it was so ordinary, so easy, that a decent man like Bo, a capable farmer, a good dyke-reeve, grew into it, step by step, without ever taking the one great step that would have frightened him.

At the dyke inspection that year Bo showed himself as what he was: a specialist who knew the dyke and held it well. But at one spot, where an expensive, thorough repair would have been needed, he hesitated, reckoned, deferred — and Grete, who walked along, saw it and thought of something she could not name, a family resemblance that went deeper than the features of the face. Bo shunned the expensive precaution, as his father had shunned it, and neither of them knew it was the same thing, and neither knew what it had cost the last time.

Chapter 3 - Grete

They had married in the crisis, Bo and Grete, in the early thirties, poor and resolute, as one married then. Grete was a farmer's daughter from the neighbouring koog, with a straight gaze and a head that took nothing as given, and Bo had chosen her because she was capable and strong, and she had chosen him because he had a farm and a will, and because between them, ~~The first years were hard and good~~ besides reason, there was also affection. at once, as the first years on a marsh farm often were: much work, little money, but the land bore, and the children came, and Grete made a home of the farmhouse. She was not one to complain. She took hold, stretched the little, made something of nothing, and Bo, who saw her come from the stable with earthy hands or from the sluice-drain with a basket of eels, sometimes thought he had been lucky, luckier than he deserved.

At the wedding Thies Feddersen had been there too, at the edge, as a worker of the farm, not as a guest. And when Bo once stepped out into the cool evening air, Thies stood there smoking, and they were alone for a moment, the son of the man whose father concealed the breach, and the son of the man who drowned at the breach — and Bo knew nothing of either.

"Congratulations, Carstens," said Thies. "Good woman. The Petersens are decent people."

"Thank you," said Bo, a little stiff, for he sensed that something lay between Feddersen and Carstens, an old coldness whose ground he did not know.

Thies smoked and looked at him, long. "You don't know much, do you," he said at last. "About your family. About what was. About the flood."

"What's supposed to be with the flood? That's thirty years ago."

"Ask your father," said Thies, and then it occurred to him that Hauke was dead, and something crossed his face. "Or ask the book. The dyke book. If you can read what's in it." He trod out the cigarette. "Mind yourself in the times that are coming, Carstens. Bad times are coming. And in bad times it shows who a man is. Some families," he looked at Bo, "some families have already shown once what they do when it gets tight. They look away. They save at the wrong end. Mind you don't look away where you ought to look."

Bo did not understand the barb. He heard an embittered labourer making dark hints, and he did not want to understand them, because it was his wedding day. "I don't look away," he said, almost amused. "I have nothing to look away from."

"Everyone has something to look away from," said Thies. "Sooner or later. That's just it." And he went back to his work, and Bo stayed in the evening air, and the sentence stuck in him, without his knowing why, like a stone in the shoe.

Inside, later, Bo thought no more of it. But Grete, who had seen the short conversation from afar, asked him: "What did Thies want?" And Bo said: "Nothing. Old stories. He's embittered, the man, ever since his father drowned, back then in the flood." And Grete remembered the name and the bitterness, and she remembered that there was something between the families that no one spoke of, and she was a woman who remembered things and did not forget.

Chapter 4 - The Quota

With the rearmament came the pressure on the land. The Reich wanted to be self-sufficient, independent of imports, and that meant: the farmers had to deliver, more and more, and the quota that Bo had to administer rose year by year. It was a screw that slowly tightened, and Bo tightened with it, for that was his office. He collected the quota, even from the poorest, even where it hurt. Old Petersen did not deliver enough, and Bo pressed him, and Petersen finally delivered by giving up his seed corn, and Bo knew that meant the next shortage, and collected it all the same, because the quota was the quota. He told himself he had no choice; the quota came from above, he only carried it out. It was true and was a lie, both at once, as always.

The years of rearmament were good years for Bo's own farm. Prices rose, demand was there, and a hereditary farm, protected and favoured, prospered. A modest prosperity returned, greater than under old Hauke: new implements, a second horse, a further child. Bo rose, and the rise confirmed to him that he was doing right, that joining-in and being-capable paid off, and he did not ask at whose cost the rise came, as little as his father had asked.

The price was the looking-away. People disappeared, here too, in the wide, flat marsh, where one thought oneself far from everything. A neighbour who had talked too loud. A travelling worker who was not the right sort. One lowered the gaze, and Bo lowered it with them, and told himself it was none of his affair, he was a farmer and dyke-reeve, no politician, and what those up there did was not his business. It was the attitude of most, and it

was complicity, and the transition between the two was so fluid that none could name the point at which the one became the other.

Grete held her distance, inwardly. She did not go to the meetings when she could avoid it, did not sing the songs, hung out the flag only when she had to. She held the family together and the children out of the worst, as well as she could, and she saw her husband change and said little, for what should she have said, against the time, against the office, against Bo's conviction that he was only doing his duty.

Once, in those years, on a Sunday, they sat five together in the garden behind the warft, Bo, Grete, the children, and it was a picture of peace: the sun, the growing cabbage, the children playing in the grass. It was a real peace, not a pretended one, an hour of happiness. But over the garden, behind the dyke, lay the water that came and went twice a day, and over the land lay the time that ran toward a war, and Bo sat in his happiness and did not know it was on loan, and that the reckoning would come, as it always came, and that the children who now played in the grass would one day have to pay for what the fathers did and looked away from.

Chapter 5 - War on the Coast

The war came in 1939, and this time no one marched off with flags and music, at least not in the marsh, where the old still remembered the last one, the names the pastor had read from the pulpit. They were silent when the news came, a silence that knew more than any cheering. The young men went off, from the koog as from everywhere, and the flat land grew empty, emptier still than in the last war. Bo stayed; he was a farmer and dyke-reeve and local farm leader, indispensable, needed where he was. But the work remained, and the hands were lacking: the dyke had to be held, the land tilled, the quota delivered, and all with fewer people, with old men, women, children.

And the quota grew. The war devoured, and the land had to nourish, more and more, and Bo collected it, as he had always collected it, with the hardness of one who tells himself he has no choice. Every repair at the dyke became a question of sacrifice, every sack of corn a duty. Bo manoeuvred, held farm and dyke and office together, and it wore on him, and he grew harder at it, more closed, a man who only functioned.

Then the first foreigners came onto the farms. Prisoners of war first, then the deported from the occupied lands, forced labourers, as one euphemistically called them, as if it were a kind of work and not a kind of slavery. They were assigned to the farms, because the men were lacking, and the Carstens farm too got assigned what was due to it by the size of the holding: hands that were not allowed to ask whether they wanted to.

Bo saw the first come, and he lowered his gaze, as he had learned to lower his gaze. They were people, emaciated, in rags, marked, and Bo treated them as what the system made of them: as tools, as labour, rightless. He told himself it was the war, not him; he had not deported them, he only deployed them, as was prescribed. It was the old self-deception, and it carried Bo, as it had always carried him.

Grete saw the foreigners differently. She saw people, and she saw how they were treated, and something in her rose up, quietly, helplessly. She said nothing before Bo, who had the office and the regulation, but she began, in secret, to do what she could: a piece of bread, a warm soup, secretly, in the dusk, passed to the assigned workers. It was little, and it was dangerous, for whoever helped the forced labourers beyond the prescribed made himself suspect. Grete did it all the same, without ado, as she did everything that had to be done.

And over the marsh lay the war, far off still, at fronts from which only the news came, and the dyke had to be held, and the quota delivered, and the foreigners worked and were silent, and Bo looked away, and Grete looked, and between them grew, unsaid, a difference that would soon become the question before which a human being must decide.

Chapter 6 - Henryk

Henryk Wójcik came in the spring of 1941, with a transport from the east, and was assigned to the Carstens farm, under Bo. He was nineteen, a slight boy with light eyes and hands that were deft, a farmer's son from a village near Thorn, whom they had dragged off his field, into a marsh he had never heard of, into a language he did not understand, into a labour meant to use him up. On his chest he wore a sign, a sewn-on piece of cloth that marked him as what he was in the language of the time: a man of the second class, a tool. He was not allowed to eat at the family table, not into their house, not into the church. He slept in a chamber over the stable, got less and worse food, and more work, harder. He was rightless, and all knew it, and most behaved accordingly.

Bo was Henryk's master. So the situation was, soberly: a man who as a boy had scuffled with the Feddersen boy, who was good with Grete and carried his children on his shoulders, was now set over another human being like over an animal, with power over his life, and the time demanded that he exercise this power like over an animal.

In the first weeks Bo lowered his gaze. It was his method. He assigned Henryk where there was work, drove him where the quota demanded, and did not look at him while doing it, for to look at him would have meant to see him as a human being, and that Bo could not bear. So he looked away, treated the tool as a tool.

But Henryk would not let himself be quite overlooked. He was a good worker, that was the first thing that penetrated Bo's lowered gaze: the boy could handle the land, had a feel for the dyke, for the water, learned quickly what was to be done. And he bore a dignity, despite the rags, despite the sign, an uprightness that shone through everything, and precisely it made it hard for Bo to see him as an animal, for animals have no dignity.

Grete passed Henryk food over the stable door. She did it secretly, in the dusk, a piece of bread, a bowl of what was left, and Henryk took it with a look that said more than words. It was dangerous; whoever supplied forced labourers beyond the measure was punished. Grete did it all the same, and she said nothing of it to Bo, because she knew it would burden him, him, the local farm leader, the man with the office.

Bo noticed it all the same. The bread that was missing. Grete's way in the dusk. Her silence about it. And he said nothing, and in his silence lay for the first time not only looking-away, but also something else: a quiet tolerance, almost a gratitude, that his wife did what he did not dare, that in his house someone did the right thing, even if it was not he. It was little. But it was a first crack in his looking-away, a first light, and it came, the way the good often comes, not through him, but through the woman at his side.

Chapter 7 - On the Ice

It happened in the ice winter of 1942, at the sluice-drain, where the water between koog and outer dyke was regulated. Bo had gone out to check the sluice, for the frost was straining the gates, and the ice stood thick on the drain, and Bo stepped onto it to free an iced-up spot at the weir, and the ice, which looked firm, broke. He sank in, into the ice-cold water, which lamed his limbs at once, and the suck pulled him under the ice, toward the sluice, and for a moment there was the cold clarity of death, the knowledge that in such water one had minutes, no more, that the cold killed faster than the drowning.

Henryk was nearby, at the dyke, and he saw it, and he acted without hesitating. He lay flat on the ice, to spread his weight, and pushed himself forward, to the break, and held Bo out a dyke-batten, which Bo grasped in lying, and pulled, with a strength one would not have credited the slight body, pulled Bo out of the hole, across the ice, onto land. It went quickly and without words, and then they both lay on the firm ground, Bo soaked and blue with cold, and Henryk beside him, gasping.

It was the same scene that had once bound Hauke and Momme, nearly forty years earlier, on the same coast, in the same water: a man who pulled another out of the water. The water repeated itself, the way it always repeated itself, and put to Bo the same question it had once put to his father: what do you owe the one who saved your life?

Bo looked at Henryk, for the first time really looked at him, the boy who had just saved him, him, the master, the man of the

system that had deported Henryk. Henryk could have watched the ice pull Bo under; no one would have held it against him, no one could have proved it against him. Instead he had saved him, out of a reflex of humanity that sat deeper than all circumstances, and in this reflex lay an accusation sharper than any reproach: Henryk had shown himself a human being in the moment when Bo treated him as a tool.

"Dziękuję," said Bo, the one Polish word he had picked up, thank you, and it was the first time he addressed Henryk like a human being.

Henryk only nodded, curtly, and helped Bo up, for Bo had to get into the warmth, quickly, before the cold took him after all. In the weeks that followed Bo did what he could, which was little and dangerous. He assigned Henryk the lighter work where it was possible. He slipped him bread, secretly, as Grete did, the Bo-bread to the Grete-bread. He turned a blind eye to small offences. It was a requital in small things, an attempt to pay off the debt of his life, and it was as insufficient as Hauke's charity once was, a means of living with one's own complicity, more than a real making-good.

Grete saw the change and was glad and worried at once. "Be careful," she said. "They see everything. If they notice you're sparing him, it's worse for him and for you too." And then, more quietly: "But if you help him, then help him properly. Half helps no one. Half is only for your conscience." And Bo knew she was right, as she was always right, and he feared the day when the half would no longer suffice, when he would have to choose, wholly, as his father had once had to choose.

Chapter 8 - The February Flood

It came in February 1943, a heavy storm tide, at northwest storm and high tide, and the whole koog was called to dyke watch, as ever, every man to his section. But there were few men, for the war had taken them, and so was called up whoever was there: old men, half-grown boys — and the forced labourers, who, rightless as they were, could be set at the most dangerous spots without anyone asking. Bo divided the watches. It was his duty as dyke-reeve to distribute them, and there was a spot that was softened, dangerous, where the water pressed, a spot that needed an experienced, alert man — or one whom one could burn through, if it went wrong. And Bo, under the pressure of the night, with too few hands, before the choice of setting a farmer or a forced labourer at the spot, said: "Henryk. You take the spot at the weir. You know it."

It was true, Henryk knew the spot. And it was a pretext, for the true reckoning was a different one: if the spot held, it was good; if it did not hold, it was a forced labourer, no farmer, no son of the koog. Bo did not think it so clearly. He would never have dared to think it so clearly. But beneath the words, there where a man decides before he knows he has decided, the reckoning was already made, the same reckoning his father had made when he set Momme at the faulty spot.

Bo could have done it otherwise. He could have set Henryk at a safe spot, the one who had saved his life, to whom he owed everything. He could have set himself at the dangerous spot. He did not. He set Henryk at the spot at the weir, and Henryk went,

through the storm, without contradiction, for a forced labourer had no contradiction, and Bo watched him go, and in him was a pull he knew and would not name.

In the night, at the peak of the flood, the spot at the weir gave way. Not wholly, not to a breach as in 1906; the dyke held, barely, because one stacked sandbags in time. But the water took what stood at the spot, in a moment when a breaker washed over the dyke, and that was Henryk. They found him in the morning, a stretch inland, in the silt, where the water had carried him, as it had once carried Momme.

Bo stood in the morning at the spot, and it was the same knowledge his father had carried that he now carried: he had saved his own, a farmer, a son of the koog, by setting another at the dangerous spot, one who had saved his life, to whom he owed everything. He could have spared him. He had not done it. And no one would ever call him to account for it, for it had only been a forced labourer, a war-dead among millions, died in the dyke service, no one's guilt, an act of God, the war.

Bo was sick at the dyke, bent over, retched up the bile, as his father had been sick, forty years earlier, on the same coast, after a different flood. The body knew what the head talked itself out of. The apple had not fallen far. The Carstenses saved themselves and let the other fall, and the water had written the story a second time, almost word for word, and Bo knelt in the silt beside the dead boy who had pulled him from the ice, and knew that he now carried what his father had carried, unnamed, unprovable, all his life.

Chapter 9 - No One Asks

Henryk's death made no waves. A dead forced labourer counted for nothing in those years; he was recorded, briefly, in a list, died in the dyke service, and buried, without a cross, without a name, at the edge of the cemetery, where one buried the foreigners. No one asked how he had come to the dangerous spot, no one asked whether it could have been otherwise. It was war, and in war people died, and one forced labourer more or less did not stand out. Bo told himself, the way such things let themselves be told: it had been the storm, the water, the breaker, not him. He had only divided, the way one had to divide, with too few men, in a heavy night. Henryk had known the spot. It had been a sensible assignment. So Bo told himself, and it helped him by day, when he worked, and it did not help him at night, when he lay awake and heard the water and saw the boy before him who had pulled him from the ice.

Grete knew what had happened. She had heard the assignment, she had seen Bo set Henryk at the spot, and she had looked at Bo when they found Henryk, and read everything in his face. She said nothing. What should she have said. But between her and Bo there now grew a second silence, beside the inherited one, of which she knew nothing — a silence about Henryk, that laid itself onto the silence about the old flood, that lay in the chest, in the dyke book, unread. Two silences, one upon the other, the way the silt lays itself layer upon layer over the land.

Thies Feddersen, the old labourer, looked at Bo in those days, the way he had once looked at Hauke. Thies knew nothing exact

— he had not heard the assignment, did not know the circumstances — but he saw Bo's face, the grey, closed face after the flood, and he recognised something in it, a resemblance that made him shiver. "Your family," he said once, in passing, while clearing the dyke, without looking at Bo, "your family has its own relation to the water. It never takes you. It always takes the one beside you." And he walked on, and Bo stayed standing with the spade in his hand, and the sentence struck him like a blow, because it was true and Thies could not know how true.

Bo did not quite understand what Thies meant, and yet he sensed it. It always takes the one beside you. Momme, back then. Henryk, now. And between them the Carstenses, who survived, who gained, who rose. Bo leafed that night again in the dyke book, which lay in the chest, sought the old entry of 1906, read it once more — the faulty spot, patched and not done, the dyke-reeve warned —, and this time he came nearer the truth, sensed the connection, sensed that his father had done or left undone something that had to do with Momme's death. But he did not think it to the end. He was tired, and the war was not yet over, and he had enough to carry himself. He shut the book and laid it back, and that was his part of the silence: that he held the truth twice in his hand and twice laid it back.

Chapter 10 - The Treks

In the winter of 1945 the treks came. From the east, over the ice, over the destroyed roads, they came, the refugees, hundreds of thousands, and a part of the stream reached the coast too, the marsh, the flat land at the end of the Reich. They came with horse-wagons, with handcars, with what they could carry, women, children, old people, for the men were in the field or dead, and they sought a roof, a piece of bread, a place. The looms had to take them in. It was ordered, and it was also unavoidable without an order, for the people were there, stood before the farms, exhausted, half-frozen, and one could not leave them standing in the snow. Onto every farm came billetings, and onto the Carstens farm too, which was large and had room.

Bo hesitated. Not from hard-heartedness alone, but from the reckoning that had become his nature: the foreigners ate along, needed room, and times were tight. But Grete did not hesitate. She took in a family, a mother with three children from East Prussia, whose husband was missing, and she gave them the chamber and shared the food, without asking, without reckoning. "They have nothing, Bo," she said. "We have a roof. That's all that counts." And Bo, who reckoned, was silent before Grete's clarity, which did not reckon.

It was the same difference as with Henryk: Grete saved, where Bo reckoned. She did the human thing, simply, without ado, and Bo saw it and could not do it, and in the seeing lay a confession he did not confess to himself: that his wife was of a wood he did not have, that she did the right thing where he did the sensible thing, and that the sensible thing was often the wrong one.

With the treks came the end too. The war collapsed, the front came nearer, then the British were there, took over the control, and the old order of the marsh, the order of the flags and slogans and the hereditary farm law, that fell apart overnight. The hereditary farm law was abolished; the farm was no longer untouchable, no longer sacred, only a farm, a large farm on the coast whose owner had been local farm leader.

And that was what Bo now feared. He was compromised, he knew that: local farm leader, member, one who had collected the quota and joined in. The British and the new administration would ask who had been what, and Bo would have to answer. And there was one who knew what Bo had been, who could incriminate him: Thies Feddersen, the landless labourer, who had been on the farm all those years and had seen everything, the quota-collecting, the looking-away, perhaps more. Thies Feddersen, the son of the man who had drowned at the faulty spot of the Carstenses, forty years ago. He of all people would now, perhaps, decide over Bo's fate.

Chapter 11 - Denazification

The committee sat in the county town, and Bo sat before it, on a chair, like an accused, and it was, he thought, a strange reversal: all his life he had sat behind the table, with the list, the quota, and decided over others. Now others sat behind the table, and on their feet stood he. They read out what they knew about him: local farm leader, member, responsible for the delivery quota, master of forced labourers. It sounded bad and was the usual; many in the marsh had done the same, and one could not punish all, so one asked after the degree, after witnesses, whether one had been a slave-driver or only a follower who carried out what all carried out.

Then they called Thies Feddersen.

Bo saw him enter, the old labourer, who had worked forty years on the farms of the Carstenses, first at Hauke's, then at his, the son of the man who drowned at the faulty spot. Thies knew more about the Carstenses than anyone. He had seen the quota-collecting, the looking-away, the years of joining-in. And perhaps he knew more about Henryk than Bo thought; perhaps he had seen something, heard, sensed. A man like Thies, who bore forty years of bitterness against the Carstenses, now had the chance to take revenge, with a few sentences, before a committee that listened to witnesses.

Thies spoke. He spoke briefly, factually, without hatred, which was worse than hatred. He said what was: that Bo had been local farm leader, that he had collected the quota, hard sometimes. He said it soberly, without exaggerating. And when the chairman

asked whether Bo Carstens had been a particularly zealous, a particularly hard one, one who had done more than ordered — there Thies paused, long, and Bo held his breath.

There a woman stepped forward, a refugee woman whom Grete had taken in, and she testified about the house of Carstens: that the farmwife, Grete, had given her and her children the roof, shared the bread, without asking, when they had nothing. And another voice, from somewhere, testified that food had come from the house of Carstens to the forced labourers, secretly, at risk — Grete's bread, over the stable door, to Henryk and the others.

Thies heard that, and it changed something in his face. He could have stayed with the incriminating. Instead he said, and it visibly cost him something: "If bread came from the house for the foreigners, then the woman risked more than most here. And if bread comes from a house, not everything in it is rotten." He looked at Bo. "I have nothing in hand against Bo Carstens that would make him a slave-driver. He was a follower like a hundred others. No better. But no worse either."

It was no defence. It was a bitter justice, a truth, no more and no less, and it sufficed for survival, not for acquittal. The committee classified Bo as a follower, with a fine, a ban on public offices that lapsed after years. Bo was allowed to stay, allowed to keep the farm, allowed to go on living in the marsh. His civic life was saved, by his wife's bread and the truthfulness of a man who had every reason to destroy him.

After the session, in the corridor, Thies stepped to him once more. They stood alone, the son of the drowned man and the follower, and Thies looked at him, long, and said quietly, only for Bo: "I told the truth, Carstens, no more. It helped you, this time.

But don't confuse it with forgiveness. Your guilt I do not take from you. It lies in the land. Ask the land. Ask the book in your chest. It knows more than I." And he went, the old man, and Bo stayed in the corridor, survived, saved, and more heavily laden than before, for now he knew that Thies knew something about the book, about the old flood, and that the guilt was older than his own failure and reached deeper, to the father, to the faulty spot at which Thies's father drowned.

Chapter 12 - Rebuilding

The postwar years came, and the marsh ordered itself anew, slowly, laboriously. The hunger stayed a while yet, the scarcity, the barter, but the land nourished, as it had always nourished, and that was the advantage of the marsh over the bombed cities: Bo lost the dyke-reeve's office; the ban forbade him the public office, and a man with his past could not be dyke-reeve in the new time. He stayed a farmer, worked the farm, and the loss of the office humiliated and freed him at once, in a strange way. For without the office, without the list, without the small power, Bo was again nearer to what he originally was: a farmer, a man who worked with his hands, and in the shared work at the dyke, at the rebuilding, he found something of the old comradeship he had lost as an office-holder.

Democracy came into the koog, new dyke associations, elected representatives, a say. It was unaccustomed, after the years of command, and many an old man grumbled, but it prevailed, and Bo, who was no longer allowed an office, watched from outside how the koog ordered itself anew, freer, louder, more contentious.

Grete held the family together, through the scarcity, through the humiliation, as she had held it through the war. The refugee family stayed a while, then moved on, into the west, where there was work, and left gratitude behind and a gap. The children grew, into a new, more open time, a time that was other than the one Bo had grown up in, and Bo saw it with a mixture of relief and strangeness.

Thies Feddersen worked a few more years, then he grew too old. He died in the early fifties, the last Feddersen of his generation, alone, without land, without a farm, the son of the man who drowned at the faulty spot, who had worked forty years on the farms of the Carstenses and knew their guilt and had never been able to prove it. Bo went to his burial, as Hauke had once gone to the burial of the Feddersen widow, and stood at the back, and it was as if that too repeated itself, as if history were a tidal flow that always casts the same images onto the shore.

But Thies had descendants. A daughter who had moved away, and through her the line of the Feddersens would go on, thin, distant, but not extinguished, and one distant day a Feddersen would come back to the coast, as a Carstens would come back, and the two lines, which had never greeted each other, would meet again at the old place, at the dyke, at the water, at the spot where long ago a man drowned.

Bo, aged, prematurely aged by the war and by what he carried, stayed on the farm, a simple farmer now, and the dyke book stayed in the chest, with the entry he had read twice and not quite understood and yet sensed. And over the marsh life went on, poorer and freer at once, and before the dyke lay the old foreland under water, with the sunken Feddersen warft, and the water came and went, twice a day, patient, and remembered what the people forgot.

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Chapter 13 - The Son Who Stays

Bo had two children who reached adulthood: a son, Hinrich, and a daughter, Anke. And in them showed, as it always showed in the children of this family, the old division: the one who stays and preserves, the other who goes away and asks. Hinrich was the preserver. He was diligent, dutiful, down-to-earth, a boy who wanted the farm and the dyke, who wanted to be nothing other than a farmer in the marsh, like his father, like the grandfather. He went early to the field and the dyke, learned to read the water, took on responsibility, and Bo saw in him the heir, the one who would carry on the farm, undivided, into the next generation. Hinrich did not ask after the old story; what was past was past, and the book in the chest did not interest him. He was no brooder. He was a doer, and that pleased Bo and it also disquieted him, for he recognised in it his own looking-away, his own inability to look where it hurt.

Anke was different. She was clever, headstrong, curious in a way one did not like to see in girls, and she wanted to go away: to learn, to become something, out of the marsh, out of the narrow life at the dyke. She read, she asked, she was not satisfied with the answers of the grown-ups. And she sensed, with the fine ear of those who want to leave, that over the farm lay a silence, something unspoken, an old story that no one talked about. She once asked after the flood, after the Feddersens, after the name that sometimes fell and was quickly wiped away again, and Bo evaded, as his father had evaded, and Anke remembered the evading, the way one remembers pieces of evidence.

Grete fostered Anke's headstrongness, against the resistance of the koog, which held that a girl belonged at the farm and not in the school of the city. "Let her learn," said Grete to Bo. "Nothing holds her here. And perhaps it's good if one of the family looks outward, further than to the dyke." Bo gave way, the way men in the marsh gave way when the women were right and did not say it loud, and Anke went away, to the city, to school, and came back another, in the holidays, and brought questions with her that no one in the koog asked.

So the siblings divided the inheritance, the way the inheritances in this family always divided: Hinrich, who would stay and preserve the farm and the silence, untouched; Anke, who went away and asked and saw the world from outside. And between the two, the preserver and the questioner, would be decided — a generation later, through Anke's children, through Hinrich's children — what became of the breach Hauke had made and Bo had repeated. For Anke would have a daughter who would be called Wiebke, and Wiebke would come back, not as a farmwife, but as an engineer, and she would read the water as the Carstenses had always read it, only with other eyes, and she would open the book that lay in the chest.

Chapter 14 - Land Under, Land Over

The fifties brought the upswing, and they brought it to the coast too, in the shape of machines. Where earlier human hands had dug the silt from the watt, stuck the groynes, thrown the clay onto the dyke, now came excavators, pumps, machines that did in days what one had earlier needed weeks and many hands for. The land reclamation, the old, patient work of generations, was mechanised, accelerated, and new koogs grew into the sea, faster than ever before. Bo aged, saw the machines come and felt what old men feel when the world changes: a mixture of wonder and strangeness. He had held the dyke with his hands, all his life, with spade and faggots and the strength of many men, and now a machine did it faster and with fewer people, and it was progress, and it took something from the work that Bo could not name: the comradeship perhaps, the knowledge that one depended on one another.

But the old foreland of 1906 stayed as it was: undyked, given over to the water. One could have reclaimed it, with the new machines, could have dyked it in, the deep stretch in which the sunken Feddersen warft lay. But it did not pay; the land was too deep, too salted, and there was easier land to gain elsewhere. So the foreland stayed outside, a stretch of watt and salt-meadow before the dyke, with the remains of the Feddersen warft that no one saw any more, that only the very old knew and of which the young did not even know that a farm had once stood there.

In those years Bo began to want to say something to a grandchild. Anke had married, in the west, and brought in the

holidays a child along, a little girl, curious like the mother, and the child asked after everything, also after the water before the dyke, after the stretch where the watt was. "There was land there once," said Bo. "Earlier. Long ago. A farm stood there." And the child asked: "Who lived there?" And Bo said: "Feddersen. The Feddersens lived there." And he wanted to say more, wanted to tell, of the flood, of Momme, of the spot — and he broke off, as his father had broken off. "Come," he said. "It's getting cold." And took the child by the hand and went back to the warft.

The child, though, remembered the name, Feddersen, and the stretch of water where a farm had stood, and it remembered that the grandfather had wanted to say something and had not said it. It was Anke's daughter, and she was not yet called Wiebke — that would be only a generation later — but she carried the curiosity on, the not-forgetting, the asking, and through her it would go on, the thread that led from the grandfather's broken sentence to the granddaughter's opened book, across the years, patient, as the water was patient that lay before the dyke and waited.

Chapter 15 - The Dyke Book, Found Again

It was while clearing out the chest, on a grey day in autumn, that Bo took the dyke book in hand again, really in hand, not just a fleeting leafing. Grete had said the old chest had to be cleared out, it took up room and was full of old junk, and Bo had sat down and gone through what a hundred years of farm history had gathered: leases, parish-register entries, yellowed letters — and the dyke book, the heavy, leather-bound book that Hauke had taken over from Okke and Bo from Hauke. This time Bo read the entry of 1906 fully, slowly, with the eyes of a man who now knew himself what it meant to leave a spot undone at the dyke, to set a person at a dangerous spot. He read: the faulty spot by the sluice. Patched and not thoroughly done. The dyke-reeve warned. Date. Okke's hand. And beneath it, what Bo had earlier overlooked, a second note, briefer, in the same hand: after the breach. A dead man at the said spot: M. Feddersen, who had the watch.

And now what Bo had known in fragments all his life fitted together. His father Hauke, dyke-reeve in 1906, had known the faulty spot and not had it done, out of thrift. The dyke broke at this spot. And at the spot Momme Feddersen died, who guarded it — Thies's father. Hence the bitterness of the Feddersens. Hence the silence. Hence the father had wanted to speak of the spot at his deathbed and had not been able to. On that, on this concealed omission, stood the farm, the won land, the whole prosperity of the Carstenses.

Bo sat long still with the book. And he saw, with a clarity that made him colder than the autumn day, the repetition: what his

father had done to Momme, he had done to Henryk. A faulty, a dangerous spot. A man one set there. A dead man who saved one's own. And a silence about it that one carried on. The apple had not fallen far. Two generations, the same guilt, almost word for word, and the book in his hand proved the first and sensed the second.

Bo wrestled with the book, as his father had once wrestled with it. He could tear out the page, erase the truth, destroy the last testimony — and with it the possibility that anyone would ever learn what the farm stood on. Or he could leave it, pass it on, as Hauke had passed it on. He took the page between his fingers.

And he left it. Like his father he left it standing, the entry, the truth, and he did not quite know why, only that he could not do it, destroy the page, as little as he could speak the truth. Perhaps it was cowardice. Perhaps it was something else, something that was almost hope: that one day there would be a human being, braver than he, braver than his father, who opened the book and read and said what two generations had concealed. He laid the book back in the chest, and Grete saw him do it, saw his face, and she knew that he now carried both: the father's guilt, which he had finally understood, and his own, which so resembled the first.

"You read it," said Grete quietly. It was not a question.

"I read it," said Bo. And they said no more, for there was no more to say, and the silence that now lay between them was fuller than any word: the knowledge of two people of two guilts, the one old, the other fresh, and both enclosed in a chest, in a book, in a land that let nothing be forgotten.

Chapter 16 - What the Land Holds

Bo grew old on the farm, prematurely aged by all he carried, and in his last years he often went to the dyke, to the sluice, where Hauke had stood, and looked over the land and over the water that lay before the dyke, over the old foreland with the sunken war. Henryk's death sat in him as 1906 had sat in Hauke, and with the years it grew not lighter but heavier, for an old man has time to remember, and the forgetting that work grants the younger, age grants no more. He saw the boy before him who had pulled him from the ice, and he saw how he set him at the spot at the weir, and no year made that better.

Once, in those last years, when Anke's daughter was visiting again, the curious child, already bigger now, almost a young woman, Bo sat with her at the dyke, and he began to tell. "There was one," he said. "In the war. One who worked for us. Henryk was his name. He saved my life, on the ice. And I —" He faltered. The young woman looked at him, waiting, and Bo felt the sentence rise, the whole sentence this time, the truth about Henryk, about the February flood, about the spot. And behind it, older, the other truth, about the father, about Momme, about the book in the chest.

"And you what, Grandpa?" she asked.

And Bo broke off. It was too big. It was too heavy. And she was young, he told himself, one must not lay such a thing on a young person. It was a pretext, and a part of him knew it, the old Carstens pretext, rather keep the heavy than speak it. "I couldn't help him," said Bo. "The war. The water. One couldn't help

many." And he took the young woman by the hand. "Come. It's getting cold."

But she did not quite let it drop, the young woman, Anke's daughter, Wiebke's mother. She remembered the name Henryk, and the broken sentence, and the word "faulty spot" that Bo had once muttered in half-sleep, and she would pass it on, without knowing it, to her own daughter, who would one day come back to the coast.

Bo died in his late years, at the window from which one saw the dyke, and Grete found him in the morning, his face finally calm. He had never said the word, neither word, neither about Henryk nor about the father. He took it with him, almost whole. Almost. For in the chest lay the dyke book, with the entry, and in the young woman lay the memory of a broken sentence, and that was enough, just enough, that it could one day break open.

The modernisation marched on, the koog grew safer, the dykes higher, the machines mightier, and the marsh forgot faster than it had forgotten before. But before the dyke still lay the calm, treacherous water over the old foreland, and it came and went, twice a day, and remembered what the people forgot, and waited, patient, for a time not yet born — a time in which the water would rise, higher than ever, and reclaim what one had taken from it, and lay bare what one had hidden in it.

DRITTER BAND

Depoldering

Sankt Annen, present day

Chapter 1 - Return to the Coast

Wiebke Carstens came back to the coast on a day in late summer, and the first thing she saw was how near the water had come to the land. She had the gauge records in her bag and the commission to plan a depoldering, and she was engineer enough to know the figures before she measured them: the sea level was rising, faster than the old forecasts, the storm tides came higher and more often, and the dyke at the Sankt-Annen-Koog, old and not to be held in the long run, was on the list of sections one had to give up to save others. She was thirty-eight and had not been here since her childhood, not properly. Her mother had gone away from the marsh, as her mother Anke had gone away, and Wiebke had grown up in the city, had studied hydraulic engineering, had become a coastal engineer — and yet, when the road reached the dyke and she saw the warften lying flat over the land, and the dyke, and behind it the grey water, something contracted in her that she had believed long since left behind.

She put up in the village, in the only inn, and on the first evening she went out to the dyke. The Carstens warft still stood, up on the koog's rise, and on it her cousin Jan farmed, the heir to the farm, the son of Hinrich, the preserver. Wiebke barely knew him; the family had scattered, the line that left and the line that stayed greeted each other politely and as strangers.

In the village something swung along that Wiebke could not interpret: an old coldness when the name Carstens fell, a certain silence, a not-quite-looking-at-each-other between certain families. She pushed it aside. She was not here to dig in family

histories. She was here on account of a dyke that could no longer be held, and on account of a plan that many would not like.

For the word she brought was a word that awoke resistance in the koog: depoldering. It meant not to raise a dyke but to give it up; to build a new dyke further inland and give the land between back to the sea, to the water, to nature conservation. It meant giving the sea back what generations had wrested from it, and for the people of the marsh, whose whole history was a struggle for reclaimed land, that was almost a blasphemy: to give up land, voluntarily, to leave it to the water.

Wiebke stood at the dyke, in the last light, and looked over the land her forebears had won, and over the water that reclaimed it, and she knew that her work here would stir up more than just silt. She did not yet know how much more. She did not know that the land she was to give back to the sea included precisely that old foreland a flood had taken over a hundred years before, and that beneath the water she would let rise lay a sunken warft and with it the truth of her own family.

Chapter 2 - The Cousin and the Land

Jan Carstens was a man in his forties, terse, stubborn, down-to-earth, a farmer who carried on the farm of his father Hinrich, as Hinrich had taken it from Bo. He received Wiebke politely and coolly, with the mistrust of the settled toward the incomer, even if the incomer was a Carstens. "So you want to give up the dyke," he said, when they sat in his kitchen, over the coffee his wife had poured. It was not a question, it was a reproach.

"I don't want to give it up," said Wiebke. "I want to save what can be saved. The old dyke can't be held in the long run, Jan. The water is rising. If we do nothing, it breaks at some point, in a heavy flood, and then we lose everything, uncontrolled. If we depolder, we give up one stretch, controlled, and secure the rest behind it. That's not giving up. That's strategy."

"It's giving up." Jan set the cup down. "The stretch you want to give up, that's my foreland. My best land, out before the dyke. My forefathers wrested that from the sea, generation by generation, with their hands. And you come from the city and want to give it back to the water, with a stroke of the pen." He looked at her. "Whoever will not dyke must yield, it always was with us. Now I suppose it means: whoever can dyke must yield all the same, because the city wills it so."

Wiebke knew the saying, she had heard it from her mother, who had it from Bo. And she saw the land with Jan's eyes for a moment: generations of work, sweat, hands in the silt, all of it given back to the water. It was not incomprehensible, his anger. But she saw it also with the engineer's eyes: the foreland was

deep, the dyke before it decrepit, the costs of its upkeep rising into the unaffordable, and the water rose further, unstoppable. It was not to be held, neither economically nor physically. That was no question of will. That was a question of gravity and of money.

"I understand what it means to you," she said. "But the water doesn't ask what it means to us. It rises. And we can choose whether we retreat in order or drown in disorder. We have no more choice than that."

Between the cousins it stayed at friction, and beneath the friction lay something else that Wiebke sensed and could not name: the old coldness that swung in the village when the name Carstens fell, a shadow over the family of which Jan too knew nothing exact and which was nonetheless there. Jan wanted to hold the land, not only from reason, but from something deeper, a bond to the soil that was almost religious — and Wiebke sensed that this bond itself was part of what had never let the family look, that the holding-on to the land and the concealing of an old guilt belonged together, even if she did not yet know how.

In the next days Wiebke began to research in the archive of the dyke and water board. She needed the historical gauge records, the old dyke files, the data on breaches and repairs, to underpin her plan. It was routine, preparation, number-work. She did not sense that she would in the process come upon something older than any gauge and deeper than any dyke: upon the year 1906, upon a faulty spot, upon a dead man and a name that was her own.

Chapter 3 - The Records

The archive of the dyke and water board lay in a sober building in the county town, and Wiebke spent days in it, among shelves full of files that reached back into the last century. She sought the gauge records, the breach statistics, everything that supported her depoldering plan, and she was thorough, as she was always thorough, and so she read too what she had not sought. She found the protocols of the great storm tide of 1906. The breach at the Sankt-Annen-Koog was recorded in them, at length, for it had been a heavy breach, with dead and great land-loss. She read the cause assessment: a spring tide at standing northwest, a level beyond all marks, an act of God. She read of the dead man who had lost his life in the breach, in the dyke service: a man named Momme Feddersen, who had guarded the endangered spot. Feddersen. The name that triggered the coldness in the village.

She read on, and in the board archive she found not only the official protocols but also old dyke documents the board had taken over when the dyke-reeve administration was modernised — among them transcripts from the old dyke books of the koogs. And in the transcript of the Sankt-Annen dyke book she found an entry of 1906, in the old hand of a dyke-warden named Okke Nissen: the faulty spot by the sluice, patched and not thoroughly done, the dyke-reeve warned. And beneath it, after the breach: a dead man at the said spot.

Wiebke sat quite still. A faulty spot one knew of. A warning not heeded. A breach at precisely this spot. A dead man who guarded it. That was not an act of God. That was, at least in part,

an omission — a dyke-reeve who out of thrift had not had a known weakness repaired, and a man who died for it.

And the dyke-reeve of 1906? She sought it, in the board lists, and found it: dyke-reeve of the Sankt-Annen-Koog, 1901 into the twenties, was Hauke Carstens. Her great-grandfather. The man from whom the farm came that Jan sat on today, the land the family won. Hauke Carstens had not had the spot done at which Momme Feddersen drowned, and after the flood, the survey files showed, the Carstens farm had gained land where the Feddersens lost theirs — precisely that foreland that now, a hundred years later, Wiebke was to give back to the sea.

She remembered, all at once, something from her childhood: her mother, who had once told of her grandfather Bo, who had lain dying and talked confused stuff, of a "faulty spot" and of "Momme" and of a "book in the chest". Back then no one had understood it, had ascribed it to the fever. Now it fitted. The faulty spot. Momme. The book. It had been no fever-talk. It had been the truth, which a dying man had not been able to speak and yet had not quite wanted to conceal.

Wiebke sat in the sober archive, with the transcripts before her, and grasped that the depoldering she was planning would lay bare more than just the old sea-floor. It would, when she gave the foreland back to the water and the silt was carried off, perhaps lay bare the sunken Feddersen warft — the place at which her own family had buried a guilt, a hundred years old, embanked like the land itself. And she grasped that she now, as the first in four generations, had the choice that Hauke and Bo had not made: to look or to look away, to name or to conceal.

Chapter 4 - The Uncovered Foreland

The depoldering works began in autumn, with the preliminary survey: one measured the foreland, mapped the subsoil, determined where the new dyke would run and where the old one would be opened. Wiebke directed it, and it was her work to document the terrain, every metre, and so she came out, into the old foreland, the deep stretch before the dyke that had been left to the water since 1906. At low water, at ebb, the foreland lay bare, a wide, silty watt with channels and salt-meadows, and the survey works, the carrying-off of silt for the borings, laid bare what had long been hidden. At one spot, there where the old dyke had broken in 1906, an excavator struck masonry — old bricks, a foundation, a buried well. The remains of a farmstead that had stood here before the water came.

Wiebke stood before it, in the silt, in rubber boots, and saw the uncovered foundations, and she knew what it was before anyone confirmed it. The Feddersen warft. The farm that went under in 1906, when the dyke broke. Here Momme Feddersen had lived, the man who drowned at the faulty spot of her great-grandfather. Here, beneath the silt of a hundred years, lay the ground on which the history of her family stood.

It was a biologist on the project team who was there that day, a woman in her thirties, who mapped the salt-meadows and accompanied the renaturation, and when the foundations appeared, she came over and looked at them, long, with a face in which something worked. "That was a farm," she said. "Someone lived here once."

"The Feddersen warft," said Wiebke. "It went under, nineteen-hundred-six. In the dyke breach."

The biologist looked at her. "How do you know that?"

"From the records. I'm Carstens. Wiebke Carstens." She said the name, and she saw how it landed with the other woman, how something changed in her face, grew cooler, more watchful.

"Carstens," said the biologist slowly. "And I'm Lena Feddersen." She let the name stand, between them, in the silt, over the uncovered foundations. "Then we both know, I suppose, that this is no ordinary farm appearing there."

It was the first time the two lines met again, a Carstens and a Feddersen, at the same place, over the sunken warft, a hundred years after the flood that had separated them. And there lay a coldness between them, at once, the old coldness of the village, the not-greeting, of which neither had known the exact ground and which now, over the uncovered stones, got a ground. But beneath the coldness lay also something else, an attention, a recognition that they both knew or sensed something larger than their strangeness, and that this something here, in the silt, was just now coming to light, stone by stone, the way the water gave it up, the water one would now let rise again.

Chapter 5 - Lena Feddersen

Wiebke sought Lena Feddersen a few days after the find, not in the watt, but in the village, where Lena lived in an old house that had once belonged to an aunt. Lena was the last of the Feddersens who had returned to the coast; her parents had gone away, into the west, like so many, and Lena had brought back the biology studies and the love of the watt sea, into a place where her name had a history of which she knew only the outlines. "I know there's a history between our families," said Wiebke, when they sat in Lena's kitchen, stiff, full of old coldness. "I didn't know it, until I looked into the records. Now I know it. And I think you should know it too."

She laid the transcripts on the table: the protocol of 1906, the entry from the dyke book, the survey files. Lena read. Wiebke watched her read, saw how the other woman's face changed, from coolness to tension to shock. Lena knew the family legend — that her great-grandfather Momme had drowned in the great flood, in the dyke service, and that the family had impoverished afterward while the Carstenses rose, and that there was something, an old grudge, a suspicion no one could prove any more. It had been a tale, a wound without proof. And now the proof lay before her, black on white, brought by a Carstens.

"A faulty spot," said Lena quietly, reading aloud. "The dyke-reeve warned. A dead man at the said spot." She looked up. "My great-grandfather. He guarded the spot your great-grandfather knew would not hold. And he died for it."

"Yes," said Wiebke. "So I read it too."

"Why do you bring me this?" Lena's voice was no longer cool. "You're a Carstens. This incriminates your own family. Why do you dig it up?"

"Because it's true," said Wiebke. "And because in my family there has been silence for a hundred years. My great-grandfather kept silent. My grandfather kept silent, he lay dying and couldn't get it out. As a child I heard him talk of a faulty spot and of Momme, and no one understood it. Now I understand it. And I can't keep silent any more. That would be the fourth. Four generations of silence. At some point someone has to open their mouth."

Lena sat there, the transcript in her hand, and in her face many things struggled: the old grudge, which now had a proof; the shock that the legend was true; and something unexpected, a reluctant respect for the woman opposite her, the Carstens, who had come to bring her own family's guilt to light.

"What do you want to do?" asked Lena.

"I don't know," said Wiebke honestly. "That's why I'm here. It concerns you as much as me. Perhaps more. I didn't want to decide it over your head. It's the history of your great-grandfather. You should have a say in what becomes of it."

And that, Lena thought, that no Carstens had ever done: let a Feddersen have a say. She put the transcript away, slowly, and said: "I have to think about it." And they parted, the two women, without reconciliation, without enmity, with a shared burden that lay between them like the uncovered stones in the watt, and neither of them knew whether quarrel would come of it or peace, but both knew the silence was over.

Chapter 6 - Jan at the Dyke

While Wiebke wrestled with the past, Jan fought with the present, and his present was the old dyke, which held and would not hold much longer. On a day in autumn a heavy west wind came up, and with it a raised tide, nothing catastrophic, but enough to tear open a weak spot at the old dyke — seeping water, a softening section, exactly the kind of spot a dyke man fears. Jan was the first there, and he called whom he could get, and a construction crew came that the water board sent, men with sandbags and gear, and among them was a Romanian worker, one of those who today did the work for which no locals could be found any more, as earlier the Poles and the Turks. They worked together, Jan and the crew, stacked bags, secured the spot, for hours, in the wind and the spraying water, and at the end the dyke held.

And it was, as it always was at the dyke: in the work, in the danger, it did not count where one came from. The Romanian worker took hold like the others, held the bag where Jan needed it, and Jan, who otherwise thought little of incomers, reached him his hand at the end and said "good work", and meant it. It was the old solidarity of the dyke, that did not ask after a passport, the same that had once bound Hauke and Momme, before the one set the other at the faulty spot. Jan lived it, unconsciously, the better part of what his family was, without knowing that his family also knew the worse part.

In the evening, exhausted, Jan sat with Wiebke, who had come to assess the weak spot — for her another proof that the old dyke was not to be held. And Wiebke, tired and full of what she had

found in the records, told him. Of 1906. Of the faulty spot. Of Hauke, who was warned and did not have it repaired. Of Momme Feddersen, who drowned for it. Of the land their farm gained in the process.

Jan listened, and his face closed. "That's a hundred years ago," he said. "What's the point now. They're all dead. Leave the land in peace, Wiebke. Leave the old stories where they are."

"The land won't leave me in peace," said Wiebke. "It comes to light of itself. When we depolder, we lay bare the old foreland, the Feddersen warft, everything. The water gives back what it took, and with the land comes the history. I can't leave it in the silt, Jan. It's already half out."

"So you want to spread it about," said Jan. "Our family at the pillory. The farm, the land — everything we have. You're sawing the branch we sit on."

"I want to name it. Not spread it about. That's a difference." Wiebke looked at her cousin, the preserver, who held the land and the silence, and she saw in him Bo and Hauke, the same attitude, the same holding-on, the same looking-away. "You're like them, Jan. Like the grandfather, like the great-grandfather. Rather hold the land and keep silent than look. But the water is rising, and it takes the land from us anyway. The only question is whether we let the truth be washed out with it or whether we speak it ourselves, honestly."

Jan was silent, and between the cousins ran a crack, fine but distinct, the same crack that ran through the family for a hundred years: between the one who preserves and the one who names. And Wiebke went that evening from Jan's farm without their having come to agreement, and she knew she would have to make the decision alone, or with Lena, but not with Jan, who held

the land and the silence, because he could not do otherwise.

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Chapter 7 - Bo's Last Word

Wiebke had known her grandfather Bo only as an old, silent man, at the edge of her childhood, for he had died when she was still young. But she had a memory, a single one, that now, since she knew the records, took on its sense, and she brought it forth like a piece of evidence one has long laid aside. It had been at his deathbed. The family had come together, to the coast, for the farewell, and Wiebke, then a girl of perhaps twelve, had gone with her mother into the room where the grandfather lay, at the window from which one saw the dyke. Bo had talked confused stuff, the grown-ups had said, fever, the end. But Wiebke, the child, had listened, the way children listen, and remembered what the grown-ups wiped away.

Bo had talked of Henryk. "I shouldn't have set him at the spot," he had said, again and again, "not at the spot at the weir. He pulled me from the ice, and I set him at the weir." And then of a "faulty spot", and of "Momme", and of a "book in the chest", and once, quite clearly all of a sudden, in the midst of the confusion: "It all lies in the land. Don't dig it up. Or dig it up. Someone has to speak it, once."

Back then no one had understood it. Now Wiebke understood. Henryk — that had been the forced labourer of whom the farm's records said nothing, of whom only this dying sentence testified: that Bo had set him at a dangerous spot, a man who had saved his life. And the faulty spot, Momme, the book — that was the other guilt, the older one, the great-grandfather Hauke's. Bo had known both, at the end, the father's and his own, and he had not been able to speak them and yet had not quite wanted to conceal them,

and so he had left them to a child, in confused words the child remembered.

"Don't dig it up. Or dig it up. Someone has to speak it, once." That had been Bo's last word, the whole contradiction of a man who knew the truth and could not bear it, who wanted to be rid of it and keep it at once. It was no commission, not directly; it was the burden itself, passed on, with the plea to do something with it that he had not managed.

Wiebke sat in her room at the inn, with the records and the memory, and she grasped that she was now the last who knew everything — the old guilt from the records, the younger from Bo's dying word — and the first who could freely decide, because no one lived any more whom the truth would bring down, and no one any more who kept silent. Hauke had kept silent and passed it on. Bo had known it and not got it out and passed it on. And now it lay with her, and she felt the weight of a hundred years, and she knew what Bo had meant: that someone had to speak it, once, and that she was that one, whether she wanted to or not.

Chapter 8 - What to Do with It

Wiebke and Lena met again, this time in Lena's kitchen, and they wrestled with the question that had no easy answer: what does one do with a truth that benefits no one any more and harms no one any more, because all who are concerned are dead. Lena wanted to make it public, fully, at once. "For a hundred years my great-grandfather has counted as the one who simply had bad luck, who drowned in a natural catastrophe. And the truth is that he died because a Carstens saved at the wrong end. That belongs in the light. That's the least one owes him."

Wiebke was more cautious. "What good does it do him? He's been dead a hundred years. No scandal rehabilitates him any more."

"It does his memory good. His descendants. The truth."

"And it shames mine," said Wiebke. "My cousin Jan, who can do nothing about it. And perhaps it shames more than just us. Whoever in this marsh has come up a little, over the generations, has perhaps also saved at the wrong end sometime, looked away, taken an advantage where another lost. If we open this up, where does it stop?"

She was tempted, Wiebke felt it, tempted to let it rest. It would have been so easy. No one knew the records except her and Lena. She could lay them back, carry the plan through technically, flood the foreland, and the old story would stay where it had lain a hundred years: in the silt, under water. It was the same temptation that had bound her great-grandfather and brought her grandfather to silence, and Wiebke recognised it: it worked not through threat but through reason, through the quiet voice that

says it is better for everyone to let the heavy rest. So all the Carstenses had kept silent. So the marsh kept silent about so much. Silence was cheap, and speech was dear, and Wiebke understood for the first time fully why four generations had chosen the cheap.

She chose the dear. But she chose it her way, not Lena's.

"I won't make it a scandal," she said. "No opening-up, no accusing, no pillory. Nothing gets better from that, it only breeds new grudge, and our families have had grudge long enough. But neither do I bury it. That's the third way, Lena, between the silence and the scandal: we name it. We give the truth where it belongs. There'll be a chronicle, for the depoldering, for the history of the koog — and there's to be a memorial plaque at the uncovered place, at the Feddersen warft. That's where it belongs, all of it: the flood of nineteen-hundred-six, the faulty spot, the death of your great-grandfather, with names, certified, readable. Not hidden and not blown up into a scandal. Simply true. Simply there. Whoever wants to know it can read it. No one who doesn't want to has to. But it is no longer hidden."

Lena thought a long time. "That's less than I wanted," she said at last.

"I know. But it's more than any Carstens ever admitted. And it's what I can carry without doing new harm. Momme Feddersen gets his name back, with the truth, in the chronicle, on the plaque, forever. And Hauke Carstens gets his too, beside it, with what he did. Both names, both truths. That's justice, as far as I can give it."

And Lena, after a long silence, nodded. "Good," she said. "I'll go that way with you. But we do it together, Wiebke. A Feddersen and a Carstens. So no one can say it's the revenge of

the one or the whitewash of the other."

"Together," said Wiebke, and they shook hands, a Carstens and a Feddersen, for the first time in a hundred years, over the table on which the records lay, and it was no reconciliation, not yet, but it was the beginning of something larger than the enmity they had inherited, and smaller than the forgiveness neither of them had to give: a shared looking, a shared naming, the end of the silence.

Chapter 9 - The Koog Speaks

Wiebke laid both before them, in the same week: the depoldering plan with the unavoidable opening of the old dyke, in the village hall, before the whole koog, and, as part of the accompanying chronicle, the historical truth about the flood of 1906, which she and Lena had written down together, soberly, with evidence, without accusation. The town meeting was full, for it was about land, about home, about the future of the koog, and that brought the people, as it always brought them. Wiebke explained the plan: the new dyke inland, the opening of the old one, the foreland given back to the sea and to nature conservation. She explained the necessity, the rising level, the costs, the safety. And she saw that she met resistance, the anger of those who would lose land, Jan above all, and the deeper aversion of a kind of people whose whole history was reclaimed land and for whom giving up land was like a defeat.

And then, when it came to the chronicle, to the history of the koog one wanted to publish for the depoldering, Wiebke brought the other matter to speech: that the flood of 1906 had not been only an act of God, that there had been a known faulty spot, a warning, an omission, and a dead man who died for it. She named the names, both: Momme Feddersen, who drowned, and Hauke Carstens, the dyke-reeve, who had not had the spot done. Her own great-grandfather.

The koog did not react with the outcry Lena had perhaps expected and feared. It reacted with the old reflex of the marsh: with silence, with embarrassment, with the wish not to stir up.

The chairman of the dyke association spoke of a "historical matter that had to be sorted out factually". A few old people who still knew or sensed something came later to Wiebke, quietly, at the door, in the street, and said it was good it was out, their grandparents had always muttered something of the flood and the Carstenses and the Feddersens, and never had anyone spoken it. Others turned away. Some Carstens relatives, distant ones, no longer greeted Wiebke. Jan sat in the meeting with a closed face and said nothing.

It was no sensation, no scandal, and precisely that Wiebke had wanted. But it was also no redemption, no moment in which the silence broke and the koog breathed out. It was more sober, more laborious: an old truth was named, took its place in the chronicle, and life went on, a little different, a little more honest. Lena stood beside Wiebke as the meeting dissolved, and said: "I'd have thought it would feel different. Bigger." And Wiebke said: "So did I. But perhaps that's all there is. Not one great moment. Only the end of the concealing."

Chapter 10 - The Opening of the Dyke

The following autumn the new dyke was finished, a stretch inland, higher and stronger than the old one, built to the gauges of the future, not the past. And then came the day on which the old dyke was opened. It was no breach, no catastrophe, but the opposite: a controlled opening, planned, measured, with excavators and calculation. One dug away the old dyke at one spot, let the water flow in controlled, at a middling tide, so it did not shoot but rose, slowly, and spread over the old foreland, the deep stretch that for a hundred years had been wrested from the water or left to the water.

Wiebke directed it, as an engineer, and she experienced it at once as a descendant, and the two would not be separated. She stood at the new dyke and saw the water flow in, there where in 1906 the water had broken in, only this time not in the storm, not killing, but planned, taken into service. The sea reclaimed what one had taken from it — but this time the human gave it, instead of losing it. That was the difference, and it was a great one: not the breach, but the giving-back; not the omission, but the decision.

Jan was there. He had fought against the depoldering to the last, and he had lost, and now he stood at the dyke and saw his foreland flood, the land his forebears had won, the best land of the farm. It was a hard farewell, and Wiebke saw what it cost him, and she said nothing, for there was nothing to say that would have made it easier. Jan watched the water as it rose, over the ditches, over the old field boundaries, over the spot where the

Feddersen warft lay, and his face was stony, and then, after a long time, he said, quietly, almost to himself: "My grandfather always said the land doesn't forget. Now it forgets after all. It goes under water, and in twenty years no one knows there was land here."

"It doesn't go under, Jan," said Wiebke. "It becomes watt. It becomes salt-meadow. It lives on differently. And it doesn't forget — we've seen to it that it doesn't forget. It's in the chronicle. It goes on the plaque. The history stays, even when the land becomes water."

Jan did not answer. He watched the rising water until it reached the spot where the sunken warft lay, and covered it again, the stones one had uncovered, the well, the foundations — the sea reclaimed them, gently this time, and laid itself over them, smooth and grey. Out of the secret that had lain a hundred years in the silt, that one had brought to light and named, became again water and watt, tides, geology. Finished. And Wiebke thought that perhaps it was right so: that one first uncovered the truth, named it, wrote it into the chronicle — and then gave it back to the water, not as concealing, but as peace, as a land that finally went honestly under water.

Chapter 11 - Reconciliation

The chronicle appeared in winter, a slim volume, published for the depoldering of the Sankt-Annen-Koog, and in it stood, in a chapter on the great storm tide of 1906, the truth that Wiebke and Lena had written down together, soberly, with evidence, without triumph and without whitewash. It stood in it that the dyke had broken in 1906 at a spot known to be faulty; that the dyke-reeve had been warned and the repair had been left undone out of thrift; that at this spot a man drowned who guarded it, Momme Feddersen; and that the dyke-reeve was called Hauke Carstens. Both names. Momme Feddersen, who was no longer only a victim of misfortune, but a man who died for another's omission. Hauke Carstens, named with what he had done and concealed. The truth, black on white, for anyone who wished to read it.

And there was a memorial plaque. At the new dyke, there where one looked over the depoldered foreland, beneath which the Feddersen warft now lay again under water, one set a plain plaque, and on it stood the name Momme Feddersen, and the year, and a sentence Wiebke and Lena had chosen together: He guarded the dyke that others left to him.

They stood together at the plaque when it was set, Wiebke and Lena, in the cold wind, and looked over the water that now covered the old land.

"I can't forgive you what your family did to mine," said Lena. "That's not for me. Momme would have to forgive, and Momme has been dead a hundred years. And honestly, I don't want to forgive you either, for forgiveness would be too easy."

"I don't want forgiveness," said Wiebke. "I've done nothing I'd need to ask forgiveness for, and for what my great-grandfather did no one can forgive me, because it isn't mine. I only wanted it named. That it stops being hidden. No more."

"That's enough," said Lena. "That's more than I'd ever have expected from a Carstens." And she looked at Wiebke, and in her gaze there was not forgiveness and not enmity, but something new that had never existed between Carstens and Feddersen: respect. "You know what's strange? My brother and your cousin Jan's daughter. They know each other, from school, over in the county town. They're friends, they say. Perhaps more." She smiled, for the first time. "A Feddersen and a Carstens. Imagine."

"Imagine," said Wiebke, and she too smiled, and over the depoldered land, beneath which the old warft and the old guilt now lay honestly under water, the two women shook hands, a Carstens and a Feddersen, and it was no final stroke and no grand reconciliation, but something simpler and more durable: the end of an enmity no one would inherit any more, because the next generation was already overcoming it, without much ado, the way children overcome things that seemed insurmountable to the old.

Chapter 12 - The Last Tide at the Old Dyke

The first heavy spring tide after the opening came in February, and it flooded the depoldered foreland full, higher than it had ever stood beneath the old dyke. Wiebke and Jan stood at the new dyke and watched the water rise, over the old land, over the ditches, over the spot where the warft lay, until the whole foreland was a grey, moving surface, sea, where for a hundred years there had been land. It was a strange hour, one in which something came to an end. The old koog, as three, four generations had known it, had grown smaller; a piece of itself was now sea again. And yet it was no going-under, no breach, no catastrophe like 1906. It was an orderly retreat, a decision, and the new dyke held the water, there where one could and had to hold it.

"The birds are coming," said Jan after a while, almost reluctantly. He had resisted the depoldering to the last, but he was farmer enough to see what was happening: already in the first weeks life had come into the new watt, waders, ducks, and in summer the salt-meadows would bloom, and it would be another fertility than that of the marsh, a wilder, older one. "My grandfather couldn't have borne it," said Jan. "Land one gives back to the water. For him the land was everything."

"Perhaps," said Wiebke. "But perhaps he'd also have understood that the water always wins in the end, and that it's wiser to give it in order than to lose everything uncontrolled. He fought the water all his life. Perhaps he'd have known when a fight is no longer to be won."

They stood in silence, and the water rose, and Wiebke thought of all who had been here: of Hauke, who concealed the dyke and gained; of Momme, who drowned for it; of Bo, who inherited the guilt and repeated it; of Henryk, the foreigner, who died for another; of Thies, who carried the bitterness; of Antje and Grete, the women who knew everything and kept silent. They all had been here, at this dyke, at this water, and they all were gone, and the land they had held and lost and regained now went under water, honestly this time, with their names in the chronicle, on the plaque.

"That's the last tide at the old dyke," said Wiebke. "From now on only the new one counts." And she saw how the water washed over the last remnant of the old dyke, which now lay useless in the watt, a wall that protected nothing any more, a piece of the past the sea reclaimed. The koog, as it had been, ceased to be, and another began, smaller, more honest, with a piece of sea where there had been land, and a truth where there had been silence.

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Chapter 13 - The Dyke Book, Read

There was still the dyke book. Wiebke had not forgotten it — Bo's dying word of the "book in the chest", the transcript in the board archive, which was only an excerpt. The original, the old, leather-bound dyke book that Okke Nissen had kept and Hauke had taken over and Bo had inherited, that had to be still on the farm, in the chest, if no one had thrown it away. She asked Jan for it. It came a conversation, for Jan wanted to let the old story rest, but in the end he went up to the attic and brought down the chest, and in the chest, under leases and yellowed letters, it lay: the dyke book, heavy, leather-bound, a hundred years of dyke history. Wiebke opened it, with careful hands, and found the page of 1906, Okke's hand, the entry about the faulty spot, the warning, the dead man. There it was, the original, which Hauke had not torn out, which Bo had not destroyed, which both had left standing, for a hundred years, unread, for the one who would come.

"They didn't destroy it," said Wiebke quietly. "My great-grandfather didn't and my grandfather didn't. They could have torn out the page. No one would have noticed. But they left it standing."

"Why?" asked Jan, who looked over her shoulder.

"I think because they hoped," said Wiebke. "Not aloud, not even admitted to themselves. But they kept the book, passed it on, with the entry in it. As if they had known they were themselves too cowardly to speak it, and hoped that one day someone would come who was not. They didn't erase the truth. They only let it lie, for later. For us."

She handed the dyke book to the county archive, certified, as a historical document, openly accessible. The entry of 1906, unread for a hundred years, was now read, sorted in, part of the documented history of the koog. What Hauke had concealed and Bo had not dared to speak was now named, certified, accessible — no secret any more, only history.

And then Wiebke went one last time out to the new dyke, to the memorial plaque, and looked over the water that now stood over the sunken warft, over the spot where Momme had died, where the guilt had been buried. The water reclaimed it, gently, tide by tide. Out of the secret became again water and watt, tides, a name on a plaque, a page in a book in the archive. Finished. The guilt was not expunged — Hauke was still the one who had saved, Momme still the one who died. But it was named, brought to light, and then given back to the water, not as concealing, but as peace. And that, Wiebke thought, was all a human being could do: not change the past, only stop burying it.

Chapter 14 - What the Sea Reclaims

The depoldering at the Sankt-Annen-Koog became a model. Other sections of the threatened coast looked to it, for the problem was everywhere the same: the sea level was rising, the old dykes were not to be held in the long run, and at some point one had to choose where to fight and where to yield. Wiebke was asked, here and there, advised other projects, and she saw that what had happened at the Sankt-Annen-Koog was the beginning of something larger: a rethinking, a different relation to the water, no longer only the struggle for every metre of land, but a giving and taking, a living with the sea instead of only against it. While at one place an old land was given back to the sea, one built elsewhere new, higher dykes, secured what could be secured. They were two movements at once, the yielding and the strengthening, and both belonged together, both were answers to the same rising water. The coast Wiebke knew was no longer the coast of her forebears; it was in transformation, would transform further, and no one knew exactly how it would look in a hundred years, how much land would remain, how much would become water.

The family, no longer bound to the old soil, scattered further. Jan stayed on the farm, smaller now, without the foreland, but he stayed, for he was a preserver and could not do otherwise. His daughter, though, who was friends with a Feddersen, would perhaps go away, or stay, no one knew. Wiebke herself did not belong here, not any more; she had her life elsewhere, her work along the whole coast, and the Sankt-Annen-Koog was for her now a place of origin, not of home.

It was an ambivalent freedom. For a hundred years the family had clung to this land, to this farm, to this dyke, bound by possession, by duty, by the Spadelandsrecht, by the guilt that lay in the soil. And now the bond was loosed: the foreland was water, the truth was named, the old office of the dyke-reeve no longer existed in that form. The family was free — and freedom was also loss. Whoever is no longer bound to a land has it easier and has less hold. Wiebke felt both, when she thought of the coast that was no longer hers and yet would always remain a part of her.

She stood, on one of her last days at the koog, on the new dyke and looked over the transformed land: the depoldered foreland, now watt and salt-meadow, full of birds; the old dyke, half decayed, washed over by the sea; the warften that still stood, smaller surrounded by water. And she thought that the sea reclaimed what one had taken from it, slowly, patient, over generations, and that it was wiser to understand that than to dyke against it forever. The water rose. The coast remained a task. But it was a more honest task now, one that no longer saw the water only as an enemy, but as what it was: the element out of which this land had come and into which it would return, sooner or later, whether one kept silent or spoke.

Chapter 15 - What Remains When the Land Sinks

The years that followed changed the Sankt-Annen-Koog more slowly than one had feared, and more deeply. The depoldered foreland became a blooming watt biotope, a protected area, into which the birds came in their thousands, in which the salt-meadows stood violet with sea-lavender in summer. Where for a hundred years land had been wrested from the sea, the land now gave back, and it was not poorer for it, only different, another kind of fertility, a wider one that belonged to no one. Wiebke still came back sometimes, on account of the work, of the plaque, sometimes on account of Lena, with whom a kind of friendship had grown, cautious, over the shared burden. She would then go out onto the new dyke, from which one overlooked the whole transformed land, and look over the watt, over the warften, over the sea, and think about what had happened.

For this she had learned, in those years: that it was not the truth that redeemed. She had brought the truth to light, named her great-grandfather's omission, connected the name of Momme Feddersen with the truth, broken the hundred-year silence. And she had half believed that would redeem something, take a burden from the family, bring a peace. But it was not so. The truth redeemed nothing. Hauke was still the one who had saved; Bo the one who repeated it; Momme and Henryk stayed dead, the guilt stayed guilt, no naming made that un-happen.

What had changed was one single thing, and Wiebke grasped only late that it was enough: one had stopped concealing. One

had stopped holding the water over the land, the truth behind the dyke. For four generations the family and with it the whole koog had concealed a sunken matter, embanked, inherited; and now, with the concealed named and the land given back to the water, one could finally breathe out. Not relieved, not happy, not redeemed. Only honest.

And that, Wiebke thought, from the new dyke, over the given-back land, that was perhaps all a human being could achieve: not to expunge the guilt that could not be expunged, not to wake the dead, but only to stop hiding them. The solidarity Hauke had betrayed, when he set Momme at the faulty spot, was not dead; it had only changed its form, from the dyke watch into memory, from the struggle against the water into the shared living with it. Hauke, Momme, Bo, Henryk — they all got what was possible, the only thing Wiebke could give them: a name, no verdict. They were named, all of them, with their guilt and their loyalty, and they were no longer hidden, and that was the legacy that held when the land sank: the truth, spoken, and the breath, finally let go.

Chapter 16 - High and Low Waters

Years later, on a clear day in early summer, a woman walked over the new dyke, and with her went a child she held by the hand and who plagued her with questions, the way children do. The woman was Wiebke, older now, and the child was a great-nephew, or a great-niece — the families had mingled, Carstens and Feddersen, for Jan's daughter had married Lena's brother, and out of the two lines that had not greeted each other for a hundred years, one had become. The child holding Wiebke's hand carried both names in itself, without knowing it, and knew nothing of the old story, and that was the best of it: that for this child it was a matter of course, what the old had paid for with guilt and silence.

"What's that, Aunt Wiebke?" asked the child, and pointed out where the watt stretched, wide and gleaming at low water, with the channels and the flocks of birds.

"That used to be land," said Wiebke. "People lived there, long ago, and tilled fields, behind a dyke. And then it was decided to give the land back to the sea, because the water is rising and one could no longer hold it. Now it's watt. Now the birds live there."

"And the people?"

"They moved away. Or died, long ago." Wiebke pointed to the plaque at the dyke. "You see the plaque? There's a name on it. Momme Feddersen. He lived here, and he drowned in a great flood, over a hundred years ago. So that he isn't forgotten, his name is there."

The child spelled out the name, and then looked again at the watt. "Was it nice, before? With the land?"

Wiebke considered. It was a child's question, and it demanded a true answer. "It was hard," she said. "The people wrested the land from the sea, with their hands, generation by generation. And much wrong happened in the process, before. People looked away, saved at the wrong end, kept silent where they should have spoken. In our family too." She paused. "But there was something good there too. When the flood came, everyone helped everyone at the dyke, no matter who. That was called solidarity. That was the nicest thing about it, and it held, longer than the land."

"Do we hold together too?" asked the child.

"I hope so," said Wiebke. "I hope so very much."

They stood a moment and looked over the watt, the older woman and the child, and the wind went over the dyke, from the west, as it had always gone, and the water began to rise, for the tide was coming, as it came twice a day, since the world began. And Wiebke thought of all who had been here: of Hauke, who concealed, and Momme, who drowned; of Bo, who looked away, and Henryk, who died for him; of Antje and Grete and Thies and Lena and of herself, who had broken the silence. They all had been here, at this water, and they all were gone, and the land they had struggled over was now sea, and over the sea flew the birds, and on land a child held her hand and knew the story not as a wound, but would one day hear it as history, honestly, with guilt and with loyalty, and do better, perhaps, than the old.

"Come," said Wiebke, and took the child more firmly by the hand. "The water's coming. We have to get off the watt before the flood's here." And they went back, over the dyke, inland, away from the rising water, and behind them the watt filled, high and low waters, ebb and flood, the giving and taking of the sea, which had no end and no beginning, and which now, after a hundred

years, concealed nothing any more, but only breathed, high water and low, over a land that no longer held the guilt fast.